

PSYCHOLOGY

Languages Pathway



**SENIOR
5**

STUDENT'S BOOK



Psychology

Senior



FOR

LANGUAGES PATHWAY

STUDENT'S BOOK

EXPERIMENTAL VERSION

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FOREWORD

Dear Student,

The Rwanda Basic Education Board (REB) is pleased to present to you the Senior Five (5) Psychology Student's Book for the Languages Pathway. This book is designed to support competence-based teaching and learning, ensuring consistency and coherence in the study of human behaviour and mental processes.

Rwanda's education philosophy emphasises helping every learner achieve him/her full potential by acquiring relevant knowledge, skills, values, and attitudes that prepare him/her to contribute positively to society and seize future opportunities. In line with this vision, the Government of Rwanda places strong importance on aligning teaching and learning materials with the national curriculum to make your learning process effective and meaningful.

This book introduces psychological concepts through activities, real-life situations, and scenarios that encourage you to actively construct knowledge, develop critical thinking, and acquire positive attitudes and values. Each unit begins with a key competence and an introductory activity to spark your interest, followed by content linked to everyday experiences and supported by practical learning tasks. Units conclude with end-of-unit assessments to help you evaluate your progress.

To benefit fully from this textbook, you are encouraged to:

- Engage actively in the activities to develop analytical and practical skills.
- Share ideas with peers through discussions, presentations, role-plays, case studies, and research.
- Take responsibility for your own learning and personal growth.
- Apply psychological theories to real-life situations and reflect on their relevance.

This book is self-explanatory and designed to be learner-friendly, enabling you to use it independently while also benefiting from teacher guidance. By exploring it thoroughly, you will gain different competences needed to understand human behaviour, manage personal challenges, and contribute to the well-being of your community.



Dr. MBARUSHIMANA

Nelson Director General, REB

ACKNOWLEDGMENT

I would like to extend my sincere gratitude to all those who contributed to the development of this Senior Five (5) Psychology Student's Book for the Languages Pathway. This achievement reflects the collective effort of dedicated individuals and institutions committed to advancing quality education in Rwanda.

Special recognition is given to the Government of Rwanda for its leadership in promoting competence-based education, and to our education development partners whose technical and financial support was instrumental in curriculum alignment and the production of teaching and learning materials.

I am particularly thankful to the subject experts, university lecturers, and secondary school teachers whose professional insights shaped the content, ensuring that concepts of human behaviour and mental processes are presented accurately and effectively. I also acknowledge the contribution of illustrators and designers who enhanced the book with clear visuals and an accessible layout.

Finally, I recognise the commitment of the Rwanda Basic Education Board staff, especially the Curriculum, Teaching, and Learning Resources Department (CTLRD), for their dedication throughout the development process. Their efforts guarantee that this textbook serves as a practical tool for students and supports Rwanda's vision of quality education for all.



Ms. MURUNGI Joan,

Head of Curriculum, Teaching and Learning Resources Department/REB

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UNIT 1

INTRODUCTION TO PERSONALITY



Key Unit Competence:

Demonstrate an understanding of personality and explain how both nature and nurture shape it.

Learning objectives

By the end of this unit, you should be able to:

Knowledge and understanding

1

- Define key concepts related to personality.
- Describe individuals' behaviour based on different personality traits;
- Classify factors that make people different based on nature and nurture;
- Explain how environment and family are factors in human personality development.
- Identify major personality traits such as openness, conscientiousness, extraversion, agreeableness, and neuroticism.
- Explain how different personality traits affect language-learning performance

Skills

2

- Link the individual's lifestyle to behaviour in real life;
- Use understanding of traits to interact effectively and solve conflicts;
- Illustrate the concept of personality using real-life examples or case studies.
- Judge factors influencing personality

Attitudes and values

3

- Value the importance of developing positive personality traits such as honesty, empathy, and self-confidence.
- Appreciate the role of biological and environmental factors in shaping our personality.
- Avoid judgment of others based on background or upbringing.
- Recognise the influence of personality traits on language learning.
- Commit to applying self-discipline and emotional control in interactions with peers and teachers.

Introduction

Personality influences how people think, feel, and behave. This chapter introduces important concepts related to personality, including character, temperament, traits, nature, nurture, and behaviour. It also presents the Big Five personality traits. In addition, the chapter explains how both biological factors and environmental influences shape personality and how these traits can affect language learning.

Introductory activity



At the end of a football competition, supporters of a team that lost the final match showed different reactions. Uwamahoro, one of the supporters, grew quiet and avoided talking to others because she felt disappointed by her team's loss. Ngoga reacted differently. He laughed and said, "It's just a game; it doesn't really matter anyway."

Gisubizo felt very emotional about the loss and started to cry softly because she was sad that her favourite team did not win. Nkubito remained confident and told other supporters that the team would work harder and perform better in the next competition. Kanyana became angry and blamed the players and the coach for not performing well during the final match.

Question: Why do you think these supporters did not react in the same way, yet they all experienced the same loss for their team?

1.1. Key concepts of personality

Learning activity 1.1



In a football match, some fans jump up, others run, some fight, others just smile and remain in their seats, and there are even those who do not smile at all. What makes football fans react differently when their team scores a goal?

1.1.1. Personality, character, temperaments

i. Personality

Personality refers to the unique patterns of thoughts, feelings, and behaviours that make a person different from others and influence how they interact with the world (Cherry, 2023). Example: Amina always greets everyone with a smile, takes time to listen to friends' problems, and volunteers in her community. These consistent patterns- warmth and helpfulness are part of her personality.

ii. Character

Character is the set of moral qualities that guide a person's behaviour, such as honesty, integrity, courage, and self-discipline. It influences how people make decisions and interact with others. Example: A student finds a wallet with money inside. A person of strong character returns it to the owner, even when no one is watching.

iii. Temperament

Temperament refers to natural differences in how people feel and react. It appears early in life and is mainly influenced by biological factors that help shape personality. Example: In a new school, some students immediately make friends, while others wait and observe before opening. These reactions reflect natural temperament differences.

• The Four Temperament Types

Ancient scholars observed four distinct temperament patterns.



CHOLERIC

Natural leaders, confident, decisive, goal-oriented, and action-driven. They like to be in charge and get things done but may become impatient when others are slow. Example: The class prefect who organises group projects, pushes for results, and gets frustrated when teammates do not meet deadlines.



MELANCHOLIC

Deep thinkers, careful, organised, introspective, and highly responsible. They plan before acting and are often perfectionistic. Example: A student who creates a detailed revision timetable weeks before exams, checks every answer twice, and worries if their notes are not perfectly organized.



SANGUINE

Social butterflies, outgoing, enthusiastic, and optimistic. They love people, enjoy new experiences, and easily make friends. Example: A student who always brings energy to a class discussion, makes jokes to lighten the mood, and befriends new students immediately.



PHLEGMATIC

Peacemakers are calm, patient, easy-going, and dependable. They avoid conflict and create harmony around them. Example: During a heated group disagreement, one student quietly listens to all sides, suggests a fair compromise, and helps the group move forward.

1.1.2. Traits, nature, nurture, behaviour

i. Traits

Stable patterns of thinking, feeling, and behaving. Everyone shares the same basic traits but expresses them to different degrees. Example: Both Keza and David are 'agreeable', but Keza always puts others first, while David is agreeable mainly with close friends.

ii. Nature

The biological and genetic factors a person inherits from their parents include physical features, brain chemistry, and natural predispositions. Example: A child born to two very musical parents inherits musical aptitude. Before any music lessons, they already tap rhythms and hum tunes

iii. Nurture

The environmental factors that shape a person include family, education, culture, friendships, and life experiences. Example: A child who grows up in a home where reading is celebrated will likely develop a love for books, not because of genes, but because of the environment.

iv. Behaviour

Any observable action or response to an internal or external trigger, including speaking, moving, expressing emotions, and interacting with others. Example: When a teacher asks a question, one student immediately raises their hand (extraverted behaviour), while another thinks quietly and writes the answer in their notebook (introverted behaviour).

Application activity 1.1



1. Explain the difference between personality, character, and temperament using clear examples.
2. A student is naturally energetic, enjoys talking to others, and easily makes friends in school. Identify which temperament the student may have and explain your answer

References

1. Cherry, K. (2023). *How personality impacts our daily lives*. Verywell Mind. <https://www.verywellmind.com/what-is-personality-2795416>
2. Soto, C. J., & John, O. P. (2017). *The next Big Five Inventory (BFI-2): Developing and assessing a hierarchical model with 15 facets to enhance bandwidth, fidelity, and predictive power*. *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*, 113(1), 117–143. <https://doi.org/10.1037/pspp0000096>

1.2. Personality traits (Big Five Traits)

Learning activity 1.2



A teacher assigns a group project to five students: Keza, Muhoza, Teta, Uwineza, and Ngabo. Each student behaves differently during the project: Keza immediately starts organising tasks, creates a timeline, and reminds everyone about deadlines. Muhoza is very talkative, suggests many ideas during discussions, and enjoys leading group meetings. Teta listens carefully, avoids conflict, helps others when they struggle, and keeps the group peaceful. Uwineza prefers working alone, is stressed when plans change, and worries about the final grade. Ngabo comes up with creative and unusual ideas, enjoys experimenting, and is curious about trying new approaches.

Questions:

1. What differences do you notice in how each student behaves?
2. Do you think these differences are part of consistent personality patterns?

Psychologists studied thousands of people across different countries and cultures. They found that all human personality could be described using five broad dimensions. Together they form the 'Big Five'. Everyone has all five traits, just in different amounts (Barza & Galanakis, 2022).

1.2.1. Openness

Openness to experience refers to the degree to which a person is curious, imaginative, and open to new ideas and experiences.



Key characteristics:

Imagination and creativity: People high in openness often engage in imaginative thinking and artistic expression. They appreciate abstract ideas, art, music, and literature.

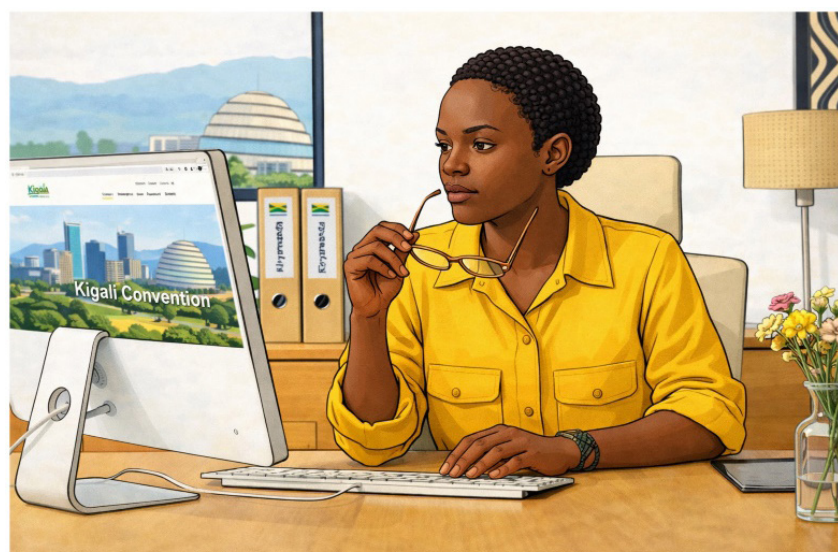
Intellectual curiosity: Such individuals enjoy learning new things, exploring complex topics, and engaging in intellectual discussions.

Preference for novelty and variety: They seek out new experiences, cultures, and perspectives rather than sticking to routine.

Tolerance for ambiguity: Individuals high in openness are generally comfortable with uncertainty and unconventional ideas. Example: A student who is excited to learn traditional Rwandan dances, writes creative Ikinyarwanda poems, and volunteers to try new science experiments in class is showing high Openness.

1.2.2. Conscientiousness

Conscientiousness is a personality trait characterised by self-discipline, carefulness, reliability, and a strong sense of duty.



Conscientious people are reliable, organised, and disciplined. They always follow through on commitments. People low in Conscientiousness may be disorganised, easily distracted, or struggle to meet deadlines.

Major Characteristics of Conscientiousness

- **Organisation:** Highly conscientious individuals prefer structured environments and well-organised plans. They often follow schedules and complete tasks efficiently.
- **Responsibility and Reliability:** Conscientious people take commitments seriously and can be trusted to complete tasks punctually.

Self-Discipline: Highly conscientious individuals resist distractions and maintain effort even when tasks become difficult.

Goal Orientation: Conscientious individuals tend to set clear goals and work systematically to achieve them.

Attention to Detail: People high in conscientiousness often show carefulness and precision in their work. Example: In Rwanda, 'Agaciro' the value of dignity through hard work and discipline, reflects Conscientiousness at a cultural level. Students who work hard without shortcuts are living this value.

1.2.3. Extraversion

Extraversion trait of personality involves sociability, enthusiasm, and stimulation seeking.

Extraverts feel energised by being around people; they love conversations, group activities, and social situations. Introverts (low Extraversion) prefer quieter environments and need alone time to recharge.

Being an introvert is not the same as being shy. Many introverts are confident, excellent speakers; they simply prefer smaller groups and need quiet time to recharge. Both extraverts and introverts can succeed in school and in life!



Key Characteristics of Extraversion

Sociability: Extraverted individuals enjoy interacting with others and often seek out social situations. They feel energised when spending time with people rather than being alone.

Talkativeness: They tend to communicate easily, express ideas openly, and participate actively in conversations.

Enthusiasm: Extraverts often display excitement, liveliness, and a generally energetic approach to activities and social interactions.

Stimulation Seeking: Extraverts enjoy excitement, new experiences, and environments with high levels of activity or interaction.

Optimism and Positive Emotions: They frequently experience and express positive feelings such as happiness, excitement, and joy.

1.2.4. Agreeableness

Agreeableness represents an individual's tendency to prioritize positive relations with others. It involves qualities such as empathy, cooperation, altruism, trust, and modesty.

Agreeableness connects strongly to the Rwandan values of *Ubumuntu* (caring for the community) and *Ubumwe* (unity). These cultural values encourage Agreeableness in daily life.



Major Facets of Agreeableness

Trust: Trust refers to the tendency to believe that others are honest, reliable, and well-intentioned.

Altruism: Agreeable individuals often help people voluntarily and show generosity and kindness.

Cooperation: Agreeable individuals value collaboration and teamwork. They prefer compromise and peaceful resolution of conflicts rather than confrontation.

Modesty: People high in agreeableness tend to be humble and avoid self-promotion. They are less likely to boast about their achievements.

Empathy and Compassion: Empathy refers to the ability to understand and share the feelings of others. Compassion involves showing care, concern, and a willingness to help those who are experiencing difficulties or suffering.

Forgiveness: Highly agreeable people are more likely to forgive others and avoid holding grudges. They prioritise maintaining relationships and social harmony.

1.2.5. Neuroticism

Neuroticism trait of personality

Neuroticism is about emotional sensitivity and instability. People high in Neuroticism experience strong negative emotions often and find it hard to calm down. People low in Neuroticism stay calm and stable under pressure. Importantly, everyone experiences Neuroticism sometimes; it is a normal human experience.



Core Characteristics of Neuroticism

Anxiety: Individuals high in neuroticism often feel tense, worried, and fearful.

Angry Hostility: This facet involves irritability and a tendency to experience anger or frustration easily.

Depression: Neuroticism is strongly associated with sadness and hopelessness.

Self-Consciousness: People high in neuroticism often feel social anxiety and embarrassment.

Application activity 1.2



1. Think about your daily behaviour at school or work. Which of the Big Five personality traits do you believe is strongest in you, and how does it influence the way you interact with others?
2. Imagine a group project where one member is very organised, another is highly social, and another often worries about mistakes. Identify which Big Five traits these behaviours illustrate

Reference

Barza, A. V., & Galanakis, M. (2022). The Big Five Personality Theory and organisational commitment. *Psychology*, 13(03), 413–419. <https://doi.org/10.4236/psych.2022.133027>

1.3. Factors influencing personality (nature vs nurture)

Learning activity 1.3



Imagine identical twins with the same DNA. Twin A grows up in a loving, book-filled home in Kigali. A distant relative in a remote village where there is no school nearby brings up twin B

Question

Will they have the same personality? Same intelligence? Same values? Why or why not?

Why are people so different from each other? One of the greatest debates in Psychology is whether we are shaped by our genes (nature) or our experiences (nurture). Modern science shows that both are essential, and they constantly interact.

1.3.1. Concepts of Nature vs Nurture

Nature refers largely to our genetics. It includes the genes we are born with and other hereditary factors that can affect how our personality is developed and influence the way that we develop from childhood through adulthood.

Nurture encompasses the environmental factors that influence who we are. This includes early childhood experiences, upbringing, social relationships, and the surrounding culture.

The physical environment:

The geography and climate of where you grow up shape your habits, lifestyle, and even attitudes. Example: People from mountainous regions of Rwanda (like Musanze) may develop resilience and physical strength through daily life in hilly terrain. Those growing up near Lake Kivu may develop a calmer, more reflective lifestyle.

The groups we belong to- friends, clubs, church, sports teams- shape our values and behaviour. Example: A student who joins a community service club may develop higher agreeableness and empathy. A student whose friend group values academic success is more likely to study hard.

Family environment

The most powerful early influence. Parenting style, family values, and the emotional atmosphere at home shape core personality traits. Example: A child raised in a home where parents discuss problems calmly and listen to each other develops strong communication and emotional regulation skills. A child who sees conflict resolved through shouting may develop anxiety or aggression.

Cultural environment

Cultural traditions, religious beliefs, and community values define what is right, normal, or admirable. Example: Rwandan cultural values such as Ubumwe (unity), Ubunyangamugayo (integrity), and kugira Ubuntu (Generosity) actively shape the Agreeableness and Conscientiousness of young people.

School environment

Schools shape not just knowledge, but values, habits, and social skills. Teachers and classmates are powerful role models. Example: A school that rewards curiosity, group discussion, and student questions produce more confident and open-minded students. A school that only rewards memorisation may limit creative thinking.

1.3.2. Interaction between Nature and Nurture

Both heredity (nature) and environment (nurture) work together to shape a person. Experts agree that neither nature nor nurture is stronger; both are important. They also interact throughout life. Genes can influence how we respond to the environment, while the environment affects how genes are expressed. Example: A child may inherit a natural ability for singing from their family, but they need to practice and learn songs to become a skilled singer.

Application activity 1.3



1. Discuss the aspects of nurture that influence an individual's personality.
2. Discuss the importance of interaction between nature and nurture in shaping an individual's personality.

Reference: *Rousseau, J.-J. (1754). A discourse on the origin of inequality: A discourse on a subject proposed by the Academy of Dijon (G. D. H. Cole, Trans.)*

1.4. Personality traits and language learning

Learning activity 1.4



In the class of senior four Languages, a group of students has just started learning French for the first time. Their teacher, Ms Uwimana, quickly notices that students approach learning differently: Kaneza is very quiet. She listens carefully but rarely speaks because she is afraid of making mistakes. Manzi is confident and talkative. He tries to speak French as much as possible, even if he makes many errors. Cyusa likes everything to be perfect. He spends a lot of time writing and rewriting his notes to avoid mistakes. Uwera enjoys working with others. She learns best when practising conversations with her classmates. Kagaba prefers learning alone. He likes using his phone to watch videos and listen to French songs. Zaninka is very organised. She creates vocabulary lists and reviews them every day.

Questions:

1. Do all students learn in the same way?
2. Manzi is confident and talkative. How does his personality trait influence his learning strategies?
3. Zaninka is very organised and likes planning. How does her personality influence her learning method?

1.4.1. Language Learning Strategies

Strategy Type	What You Do	Simple Example
Memory Strategies	Use tools to store and recall new words.	Making flashcards with a new English word on one side, the Kinyarwanda meaning on the other.
Cognitive Strategies	Practice and analyse language patterns.	Studying grammar rules, writing practice sentences, and doing vocabulary exercises.
Compensation Strategies	Overcome gaps by using clues or alternatives.	Guessing the meaning of an unknown word from its context in a sentence.
Social Strategies	Learn through interaction with other people.	Practising English with a classmate during break time.
Cultural Exploration	Engage with authentic language in real contexts.	Watching an English film without subtitles to train your ear.
Experiential Learning	Learn by doing real activities.	Role-playing a job interview in English in front of the class.
Cooperative Learning	Work in groups toward a shared language goal.	Creating a group story in English together, each student adding two sentences.
Affective Strategies	Manage emotions and anxiety about learning.	Taking three deep breaths before speaking English in class to feel calmer.

1.4.2. Personality traits and language learning strategies

Research has revealed the relationship between personality traits and language learning strategies (Chen, M& Hung, L., 2012)

Personality Trait	Best Strategies	Examples in English Class
Openness (High)	Cognitive strategies, Cultural exploration, Creative writing	Analysing English grammar patterns for fun; watching BBC or Netflix in English; writing creative short stories or poems in English.
Conscientiousness (High)	Memory strategies, Cognitive practice, Structured study routines	Using Anki flashcard apps to memorise 10 new words daily, keeping a grammar error journal, and setting a 45-minute English study slot every evening.
Extraversion (High)	Social strategies, Experiential learning, Compensation strategies	Debating topics in English; forming an English-speaking group with friends; paraphrasing when you do not know a word during conversation.
Agreeableness (High)	Cooperative learning social strategies: Seeking and giving feedback	Peer tutoring a classmate in English grammar; asking a teacher for detailed feedback on essays; celebrating group achievements in English projects.

Neuroticism (High)

Affective strategies,
Structured routines,
Self-monitoring

Breathing exercises before oral presentations, keeping a learning journal to track progress, and setting small, achievable goals each week to build confidence.

Application activity 1.4

1. Explain which language learning strategies are most effective for individuals with Conscientiousness and Agreeableness.
2. Think about your own personality traits. How do these traits influence your approach to language learning?
3. Discuss specific examples of how your traits have helped or hindered your language learning.

1.5. End unit assessment**Knowledge and Understanding**

1. Based on the dimensions of temperament, describe individual behaviour characteristics
2. Identify and describe the five major personality traits
3. Explain the difference between nature and nurture in shaping personality.

Skills

4. Compare how different personality traits may influence communication and interaction with others.
5. Develop strategies for using knowledge of personality traits to resolve conflicts effectively
6. Illustrate the concept of personality using a real-life example

Attitudes and Values

7. Reflect on how understanding personality differences can help avoid judging others
8. Evaluate the importance of both biological and environmental influences on personality development.
9. Justify the need to apply self-discipline in school interactions

Reference

Chen, M.-L., & Hung, L.-M. (2012). *Personality type, perceptual style preferences, and strategies for learning English as a foreign language. Social Behaviour and Personality: An international journal*, 40(9), 1501–1510. <https://doi.org/10.2224/sbp.2012.40.9.1501>

UNIT 2

THEORIES OF PERSONALITY



Key Unit Competence:

Assess different views of psychologists related to personality.

Learning objectives

By the end of this unit, you should be able to:

Knowledge and understanding

1

- Describe the key ideas and assumptions of the psychoanalytic theory (Sigmund Freud).
- Explain the main principles of the humanistic theory (Abraham Maslow).
- Identify the core components of the social cognitive theory (Bandura).

Skills

2

- Compare and contrast different theories in terms of focus, approach, and application.
- Compare personal experiences or observed behaviours using different personality theories.
- Critically evaluate the strengths and limitations of each personality theory.
- Apply concepts from personality theories to real-life situations or case studies.

Attitudes and values

3

- Appreciate the complexity and diversity of human personality
- Show respect and empathy toward individual differences in behaviour and personality
- Value the application of personality theories in improving interpersonal relationships

- Value the application of personality theories in improving interpersonal relationships
- Demonstrate positive attitudes by collaborating effectively in diverse groups, promoting tolerance, respect, and teamwork.

Introduction

Theories of personality refer to ideas that explain how people develop their character and behave. This unit will explore Sigmund Freud's Psychoanalytic theory. It will also cover Abraham Maslow's humanistic theory, and finally, we will study Albert Bandura's social cognitive theory.

Introductory activity



Manzi, Ntwari, and Kirezi are students in the Language pathway. **Manzi** is reserved, disciplined, and honest, spending much of his time praying and following religious guidance, but this sometimes distracts him from schoolwork. **Ntwari** is impulsive, pleasure-seeking, and careless with both studies and relationships; he cheats without remorse and prioritises immediate satisfaction over responsibility. **Kirezi** is sociable, sensible, and balanced; she manages both schoolwork and religious activities, works hard for good grades, and makes thoughtful choices about relationships, waiting until she is mature to have a boyfriend.

Question:

1. From this scenario and from a personality point of view, how can you judge the behaviour of the three students?
2. Do you recognise yourself among the three students? Explain.

2.1. Psychoanalytic theories of personality

Learning activity 2.1



Mugabo (8 years) and Rukundo (4 years) are brothers with very different personalities. Mugabo is calm, polite, and comfortable sleeping alone, while Rukundo is active, noisy, and sometimes aggressive, always wanting to sleep with his mother. This leads to conflicts with their father, who punishes Rukundo to keep him from his mother's room. Rukundo cries when his father is home, but is happy to sleep with his mother when he leaves. Mugabo often laughs at Rukundo's behaviour.

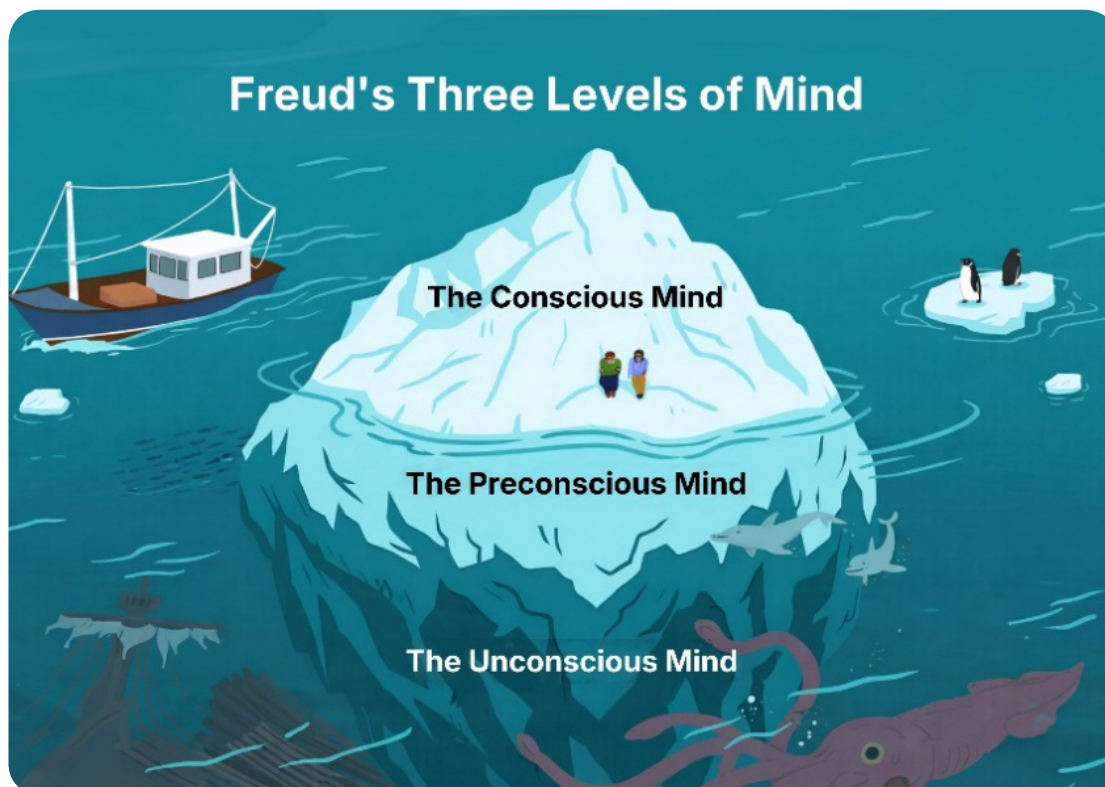
1. Comment on the behaviour of Rukundo and Mugabo.
2. Do you think Rukundo exaggerates in his behaviour?
3. Why do you think there is a feeling of hate between Rukundo and Daddy? Did you experience the same situation as a child? Explain

Sigmund Freud (1856-1939) is known as the founder of Psychoanalytic theory. In his opinion, development is beyond consciousness. He believed that children are often not aware of the motives and reasons for their behaviour and, above all, their mental activities. They valued early experiences with parents, which have a profound impact on people's personalities.

2.1.1. Freud's Model of the Structure of Personality

Freud and the mind

According to Freud, there are three levels of the mind: **conscious**, **preconscious** and **unconscious**



According to Freud, **the conscious** mind is what we are aware of, like our current thoughts and feelings. **The preconscious** stores memories we can easily recall, such as a friend's name. The largest part is **the unconscious**, which holds hidden thoughts, memories, and desires. Freud said this unconscious mind strongly affects our personality and behaviour.

The Structure of Personality

In Sigmund Freud's theory, human personality has three main parts: **the id**, **the ego**, and **the superego**.



These are not separate physical parts of the brain. Instead, they are ideas or psychological concepts that Freud used to explain how the mind works.

The id: Represents our basic desires and instincts, such as hunger, pleasure, and immediate satisfaction.

The ego: Is the part that thinks and makes decisions. It tries to balance our desires with reality.

The superego: It includes moral rules and values we learn from society and our parents.

2.1.2. Defence mechanisms

According to Sigmund Freud, people often experience inner conflicts because of strong desires such as sexual and aggressive impulses. Sometimes these conflicts go away quickly, but other times they last longer and cause stress or fear. When the ego cannot balance the demands of the id and the superego, it creates fear or anxiety. To deal with this, the ego uses defence mechanisms, which are mental strategies that protect a person from stress and unpleasant feelings (Feist et al., 2018, pp. 30–45)



Denial: Denial means that a person refuses to accept reality or facts because they are too painful or difficult to face. Example: An ill person who refuses to believe the doctor's diagnosis and acts as if nothing is wrong.

Projection: Projection happens when a person puts his or her own unwanted thoughts or feelings onto someone else. Example: A student who cheated on a test accuses other classmates of cheating.

Compensation: Compensation is defined as when a person tries to cover up a weakness by focusing on another strength. Example: Someone who is not good at sports works very hard to become excellent in academics.

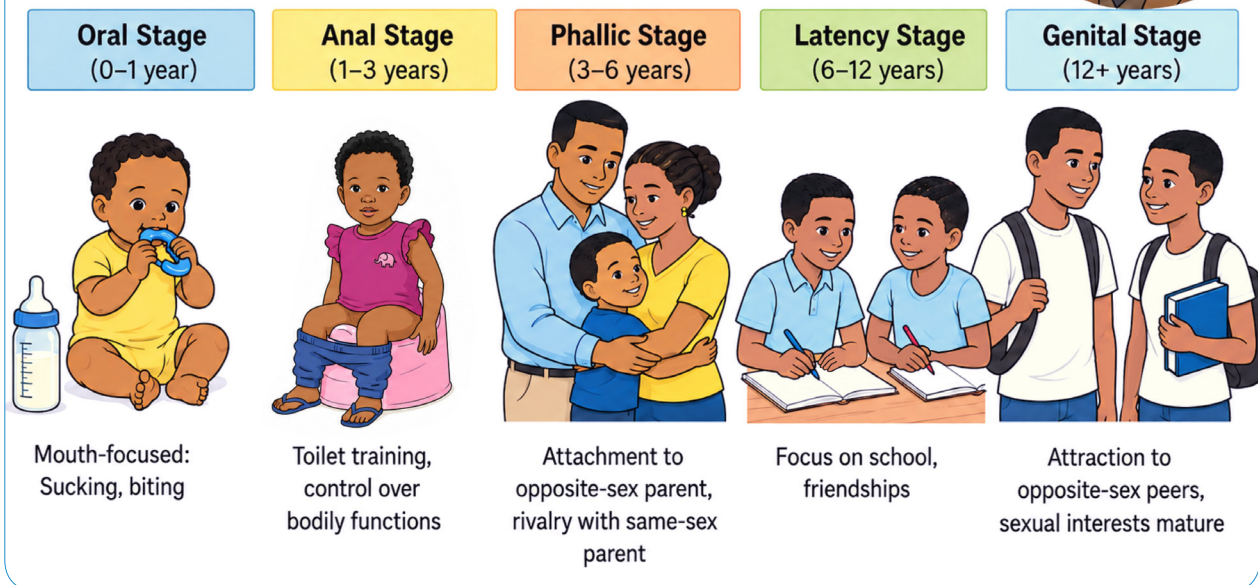
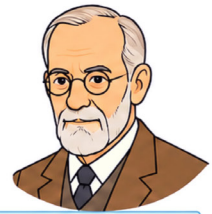
Withdrawal: Withdrawal occurs when a person avoids people or situations that cause stress or anxiety. Example: A student who fails an exam stops attending classes and avoids friends.

Sublimation: Sublimation means that a person changes unacceptable impulses into positive or socially acceptable activities. Example: Someone with aggressive feelings takes up boxing or sports to release their energy.

Rationalisation: Rationalisation is defined as when a person gives logical excuses to justify a mistake or failure instead of accepting the real reason. Example: A student who fails an exam says, "The exam was unfair," instead of admitting they did not study enough.

2.1.3. Psychosexual stages of personality development

Freud's Psychosexual Stages



Sigmund Freud believed that personality develops through five psychosexual stages: **oral, anal, phallic, latency, and genital**. In each stage, a different part of the body (erogenous zone) gives the child the most pleasure.

1. Oral Stage (Birth–18 months)

In the oral stage, babies get pleasure from the mouth through sucking, biting, and chewing. Too much or too little satisfaction can cause oral fixation, leading to habits like overeating, smoking, nail biting, or dependence in adulthood.

2. Anal Stage (18 months–3 years)

In the anal stage, children gain pleasure from controlling bowel movements and learning toilet training. How parents handle this affects personality: strict training may lead to neat or stubborn adults, while relaxed training may lead to messy or careless behaviour.

3. Phallic Stage (3–6 years)

In the phallic stage, children notice their genitals and differences between genders. Boys may feel attracted to their mother (**Oedipus complex**) and girls to their father (**Electra complex**).

4. Latency Stage (6 years–Puberty)

In the latency stage, sexual feelings are quiet, and children focus on school, friends, hobbies, and learning. They develop confidence, social skills, and knowledge important for later life.

5. Genital Stage (Puberty–Adulthood)

In the genital stage, sexual feelings return, and individuals form mature romantic relationships.

According to Freud, how children deal with conflicts between their natural desires and society's rules affects their adult personality. If children do not resolve these conflicts well, they may develop fixation, meaning they become stuck at a certain stage of development,

Application activity 2.1



1. Think about a situation in your daily life where you had to control a strong desire because it was not socially acceptable. Explain how the ego helped manage the conflict between the id and the superego.
2. A person who feels very aggressive joins a boxing club and trains regularly. The **defence mechanism** shown in that example is **fixation**.
3. A person feels afraid of dogs but does not remember any bad experience with them. Later, they discover that a dog bit him when he was very young. Explain how the unconscious mind might influence this person's behaviours in everyday life.
4. At which stage do children focus on learning self-control and toilet training?

Reference

Feist, J., Feist, G. J., & Roberts, T.-A. (2018). *Theories of personality (9th ed.)*. McGraw-Hill Education

2.2. Humanistic theory of personality: Abraham Maslow

Learning activity 2.2



Taking your family as an example, describe your life by answering these questions:

1. Do you always struggle to find basic needs in your family? If yes, explain how. If no, explain.
2. Do you have enough security at home and on the way to and from school? What are the elements of insecurity in your location?
3. Can you describe the kind of love you experience at home and at school?
4. What are your aspirations for the future?

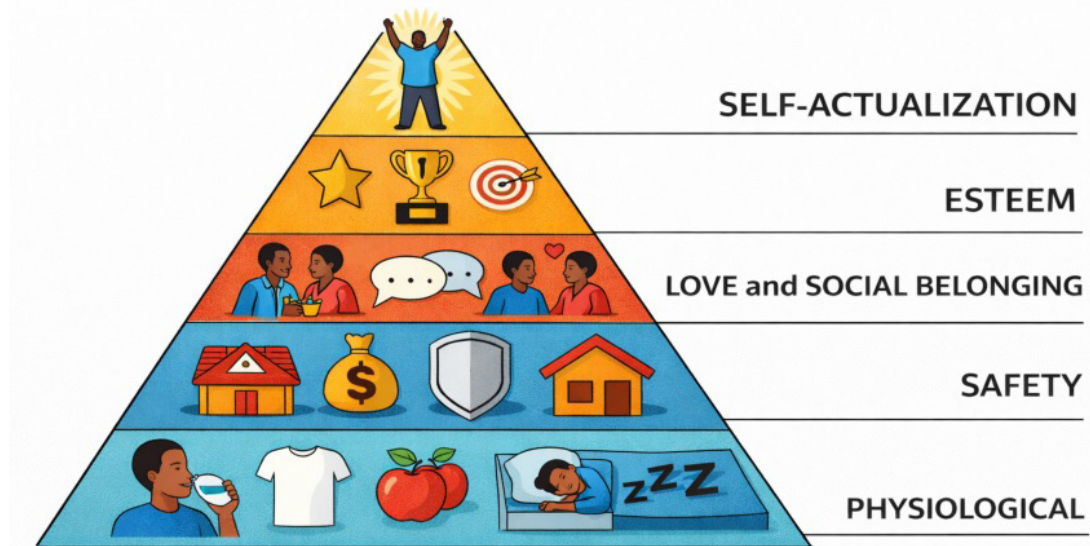
Humanistic theories of personality focus on the positive side of people, such as personal growth, free will, and reaching one's full potential. According to Maslow's hierarchy of needs, people try to satisfy basic needs first (food and safety), then love, esteem, and finally self-actualisation. This approach shows that humans grow and develop their abilities step by step (Huitt, 2007).



2.2.1. The hierarchy of needs

Abraham Maslow explained that humans have five basic needs that guide their behaviour. These needs are physiological (food, water), security (safety), belongingness and love (relationships), esteem (respect and appreciation), and self-actualisation (reaching one's full potential). The arrangement of the needs is from the most basic to the highest, and people usually try to satisfy the lower needs first before focusing on higher ones.

MASLOW'S HIERARCHY OF NEEDS



Characteristics of Needs

Maslow described several characteristics of needs

- The lower the need is in the hierarchy, the greater its priority. The higher needs are weaker.

- Higher needs emerge later in life. Physiological and safety needs arise in infancy. During adolescence, people seek belonging and esteem. In midlife, they begin to seek self-realisation.
- Because higher needs are less important for survival, people can postpone satisfying them. The non-satisfaction of a higher need does not lead to a crisis. Failure to meet a lower need leads to a crisis. For this reason, Maslow called lower needs deficit, or lack, needs; their non-satisfaction creates a deficit or deficiency in the individual.
- Higher needs, while less essential for survival, contribute to survival and growth. Satisfying higher needs leads to improved health and longevity. For this reason, Maslow called higher needs growth or being needs.
- Satisfying higher needs is also psychologically beneficial. Satisfying higher needs leads to contentment, happiness, and fulfilment.
- The satisfaction of higher needs requires better external circumstances (social, economic and political) than the satisfaction of lower needs. For example, the pursuit of self-actualisation requires greater freedom of expression and opportunity than the pursuit of security needs.
- A need does not need to be fully satisfied before the next need in the hierarchy becomes important.

2.2.2. Categories of needs

Physiological Needs

These are the basic survival needs, like food, water, oxygen, and sex. If people do not meet these needs, the needs dominate their attention.

Safety Needs

These include security, stability, and protection from harm. Example: Adults buy insurance, save money, or stay in secure jobs rather than taking risky ventures.

Belongingness and Love Needs

These are relationships and social connections, including friendships, romantic relationships, or group membership. Example: Joining a club, volunteering, or maintaining close friendships to feel accepted and connected.

Esteem Needs

Once we feel loved, we seek self-respect and recognition. Esteem has two parts: self-esteem (confidence and competence) and esteem from others (status, recognition).

Self-Actualization Needs

The highest level is achieving one's full potential and personal growth. This involves using talents, creativity, and abilities to their fullest. Example: A musician who composes music, an artist who paints, or someone who dedicates their life to helping others, fully using their talents.

Self-actualizers

According to Abraham Maslow, self-actualising people are motivated mainly by personal growth and reaching their full potential. His research on emotionally healthy individuals showed that very few people (about 1% or less of the population) achieve this level and tend to share similar positive characteristics:

Efficient perception of reality: Seeing situations clearly and realistically without distortion.

Acceptance of themselves, others, and nature: Being comfortable with who they are and tolerant of others.

Spontaneity, simplicity, and naturalness: Acting naturally and authentically without pretence.

Focus on problems outside themselves: Paying attention to issues beyond personal concerns, like helping others.

Sense of detachment and need for privacy: Being comfortable alone and valuing personal space.

Freshness of appreciation: Enjoying everyday experiences with wonder and gratitude.

Social interest: Caring about the well-being of others and contributing to society.

Profound interpersonal relations: Having deep, meaningful connections with a few people rather than many shallow relationships.

Democratic character structure: Treating all people equally and respecting their rights.

Creativeness: Thinking and acting in original and innovative ways.

Resistance to enculturation: Being independent of societal pressures and thinking for oneself.

Application activity 2.2



1. Imagine you are a manager. Propose ways to meet your employees' physiological, safety, belonging, and esteem needs to increase productivity and motivation.
2. Think of a person you know who is highly successful in pursuing their passion. Explain how they demonstrate self-actualisation and what needs they likely satisfied first.

Reference

Huitt, W. (2007). *Maslow's Hierarchy of Needs. Educational Psychology Interactive. Valdosta State University, Valdosta.*

<http://www.edpsycinteractive.org/topics/conation/maslow.html>

2.3. Social cognitive theory

Learning activity 2.3



Reflect on how the Rwandan proverb “Uwiba ahetse aba abwiriza uwo mu mugongo” relates to the idea of learning by observing. Explain how this proverb reflects the way people, especially children, learn behaviours by watching and imitating others in their environment.

Albert Bandura's Social Cognitive Theory explains that personal factors, behaviour, and the social environment interact to shape human behaviour. People learn not only from their own experiences but also by observing others and the results of their actions (Firmansyah & Saepuloh, 2022).

The theory also suggests that thoughts, beliefs, and expectations influence how people behave, and that individuals can guide their own behaviour through **reciprocal determinism** by interacting with and shaping their environment, and through **observational learning** by watching and imitating the actions of others and observing the consequences.

Reciprocal determinism is a key concept in Social Cognitive Theory. It explains that human behaviour results from the continuous interaction between personal factors, behaviour, and the environment.

Personal factors include thoughts, beliefs, emotions, and attitudes;

Behaviour refers to the actions people perform

The Environment includes the social and physical surroundings in which people live.

Albert Bandura explained that in reciprocal determinism, personal factors, behaviour, and the environment influence each other continuously. The environment not only affects people; they also change it through their actions and decisions.

2.3.2. Observational Learning (Modelling)



Albert Bandura explained observational learning (modelling) as learning by watching others' behaviour and the results of their actions. People can learn new skills, attitudes, and behaviours without direct experience.

People may learn negative behaviours through observation if they see harmful actions rewarded. Individuals may imitate aggression or dishonesty if they believe it brings benefits. This means that people learn by observing the experiences and consequences of others' actions. Example: Children observe how their older siblings dance traditional Rwandan dances so they can imitate their style.

2.3.3. Self-Efficacy and Self-Regulation

Self-efficacy

Albert Bandura described self-efficacy as a person's belief in their ability to complete a task or achieve a goal. People with high self-efficacy believe they can overcome challenges and therefore work harder and persist, while those with low self-efficacy often doubt themselves and give up easily.

Self-regulation

Albert Bandura described self-regulation as a person's ability to control their behaviour, emotions, and thoughts to achieve personal goals. It involves setting goals, monitoring progress, and adjusting actions without relying solely on external rules or rewards.

Application activity 2.3



1. Analyse how social media influencers may affect young people's behaviour through modelling.
2. Propose strategies families could use to encourage positive behaviours in everyday life using the principles of Social Cognitive Theory

Reference

Firmansyah, D., & Saepuloh, D. (2022). Social learning theory: Cognitive and behavioral approaches. *Jurnal Ilmiah Pendidikan Holistik (JIPH)*, 1(3), 297–324. https://www.researchgate.net/publication/367220348_Social_Learning_Theory_Cognitive_and_Behavioral_Approaches

2.4. End unit assessment



Knowledge and Understanding

1. Explain how observational learning works in Bandura's theory
2. Describe the role of the unconscious mind in Freud's theory
3. Outline the levels of needs in Abraham Maslow's hierarchy

Skills

4. Compare the focus of psychoanalytic theory and humanistic theory
5. Which personality theory do you think is most useful in understanding human behaviour? Justify your answer
6. Analyse a real-life situation where observational learning occurs

Attitudes and Values

7. Do you think social media has a positive or negative influence on personality development? Use ideas from personality theories to justify your answer and suggest ways to avoid negative effects.
8. Describe how understanding personality theories can help you respect others' behaviour.
9. Propose two ways you can promote tolerance and teamwork in a diverse group using knowledge of personality theories.
10. Analyse why people behave differently even in similar situations.

UNIT 3

PERSONALITY DISORDERS



Key Unit Competence:

Analyse Personality disorders in terms of meaning, classification, causes, impacts, and management to promote understanding and support intervention.

Learning objectives

By the end of this unit, you should be able to:

Knowledge and understanding

1

- Clarify the meaning and definition of personality Disorders.
- Describe the major classifications of personality disorders.
- Explain the causes and risk factors contributing to personality disorders.
- Describe the impact of personality disorders on individuals, families, and society.
- Identify different treatment and management approaches for personality disorders.

Skills

2

- Present information about personality disorders through presentations, posters, or reports
- Apply Knowledge and understanding of the meaning of Personality disorders in screening individuals with susceptible behaviours.
- Develop a diagram demonstrating personality disorders, their causes, their risk factors, and their specific management and treatment approaches.
- Evaluate the effectiveness of different treatment and management strategies

Attitudes and values

3

- Demonstrate empathy toward individuals living with personality disorders.
- Show a non-judgmental and ethical attitude when discussing or analysing others' psychological conditions.
- Appreciate the importance of early diagnosis and treatment of personality disorders.

Introduction

Personality refers to consistent patterns of thinking, feeling, and behaving that shape how people relate to themselves, others, and their environment. When these patterns become rigid and cause significant problems, they may lead to personality disorders. The unit covers the meaning and characteristics of personality disorders, their classification, the causes and risk factors associated with their development, and the impact they have on individuals and society. It also examines the main treatment and management approaches used to support individuals with these conditions.

Introductory activity



Ngoga is a 28-year-old man who works in a small company. His colleagues often find it difficult to work with him because he frequently misinterprets their actions and believes that they are trying to undermine him. At times, Ngoga reacts with intense anger to minor disagreements and later regrets his reactions. He also struggles to maintain close relationships, as his friends describe him as unpredictable and overly suspicious. Because of these behaviours, John has changed jobs several times and often experiences conflicts with people around him. His family members are concerned and encourage him to seek professional help to better understand the patterns in his thoughts, emotions, and behaviours.

Questions:

1. What do you understand by Ngoga's personality?
2. What impacts might these behaviours have on Ngoga and the people around him?
3. What treatment and management approaches could help address these challenges?

3.1. Meaning of personality disorder

Learning activity 3.1



Manzi is a student in S5 Languages. In a class group project, classmates notice that Manzi often reacts very strongly to small disagreements. If someone suggests a different idea, Manzi feels personally attacked, becomes angry, and sometimes refuses to participate. Other times, Manzi becomes withdrawn and avoids the group completely, believing others are against him even when they are not.

1. Do you think Manzi's reactions are typical or unusual? Why?
2. How do Manzi's thoughts and feelings affect their relationships with others?

A personality disorder is a type of mental health condition in which a person has long-lasting, inflexible, and maladaptive patterns of thinking, feeling, and behaving.

Features of personality disorder

Personality disorder occurs when:

Personality traits are extreme or unhealthy: Personality characteristics become **too intense, inflexible, or harmful**, to the point that they create problems in a person's life.

They are persistent over time: The patterns of thinking, feeling, and behaving last for a long time and do not easily change.

They cause distress or problems in life: The person's thoughts, emotions, and behaviours make their life difficult or create suffering, either for themselves or for others.

The person may not realise their behaviour is problematic: Sometimes, the person does not see anything wrong with how they think or act, even if it is causing harm or difficulties.

Application activity 3.1



1. How would you determine whether a person's behaviour is a personality disorder or just a normal personality trait? Explain your reasoning.
2. Do you think lack of awareness (not realising the behaviour is problematic) makes personality disorders harder to treat? Justify your answer.

3.2. Classification of personality disorders

Learning activity 3.2



Kagaba, Nyamwiza, and Nziza are students in the same class:

Kagaba is very suspicious. He often believes that others are talking about him or trying to harm him, even without evidence. He prefers to stay alone and avoids social interactions whenever possible.

Nyamwiza is highly emotional and unpredictable. She forms intense friendships that often turn into conflicts. Sometimes she becomes very angry or feels empty and disconnected.

Nziza is extremely anxious. He avoids social situations because he fears judgment and embarrassment. He relies heavily on others to make decisions and struggles to act independently.

1. How might Kagaba's behaviour affect his relationships and school performance?
2. What challenges might Nyamwiza's behaviour present for her social development?
3. How could Nziza's behaviour affect his ability to handle stress or make decisions?

He avoids social situations because he fears judgment and embarrassment. These clusters are **Cluster A, Cluster B, and Cluster C**

3.2.1. Cluster A: Odd or Eccentric Disorders

Individuals in this cluster often display unusual thinking or behaviours and may appear strange or peculiar to others.



Paranoid Personality Disorder:

Individuals with this disorder have significant problems in their relationships. Indeed, they shun intimacy. They are rigid and uncompromising; hostile, stubborn, defensive and with hypersensitivity and difficulty in getting along with others (Marmar, 1987).

Schizoid Personality Disorder

Persons with Schizoid Personality Disorder are «loners». They are excessively self-absorbed and detached, both socially and emotionally. They do better at work than they do in interpersonal relationships.

Schizotypal Personality Disorder:

People with Schizotypal Personality Disorder often think, act, or believe in ways that seem unusual or strange to others. They may feel uncomfortable around people and find it hard to have close relationships.

3.2.2. Cluster B: Dramatic, Emotional, or Erratic Disorders

This cluster includes individuals whose behaviour tends to be intense, unstable, or overly emotional.

Antisocial Personality Disorder

People with Antisocial Personality Disorder often ignore the rights of others and may break rules or laws without feeling guilty. They act impulsively, meaning they make quick decisions without thinking about the consequences.



Borderline Personality Disorder

Individuals with Borderline Personality Disorder have unstable emotions and self-image. Their moods shift quickly; one moment they feel happy, the next they feel sad or angry. They often fear abandonment by friends or loved ones.

Histrionic personality disorder

People with Histrionic personality disorder seek attention and admiration constantly and want to be the centre of attention. They show excessive emotions, which may seem dramatic.

Narcissistic Personality Disorder

Individuals with Narcissistic Personality Disorder have a strong sense of self-importance and may exaggerate their achievements. They lack empathy, meaning they have difficulty understanding or caring about other people's feelings.

3.2.3. Cluster C: Anxious or Fearful Disorders

Individuals in this cluster tend to experience high levels of anxiety or fear in social and personal situations.

Avoidant Personality Disorder

People with Avoidant Personality Disorder feel intensely shy and anxious in social situations because they fear criticism, rejection, or embarrassment. They often feel inadequate or inferior compared to others. They may avoid friendships, social activities, or new opportunities even if they want them, due to fear of failure or rejection.



Dependent Personality Disorder

Individuals with Dependent Personality Disorder rely heavily on others to make decisions or take care of them. They struggle to be independent and may let others take charge of their life.

Obsessive-Compulsive Personality Disorder

People with Obsessive-Compulsive Personality Disorder are preoccupied with order, rules, and perfection. They often try to control situations and can be very rigid or stubborn.

Passive Aggressive Personality Disorder

An individual with this disorder is thus indirect in his/her communications and actions. Rather than just saying «no, I don't want to», he/she engages in all sorts of indirect resistance. She/he finds ways of not doing what she/he is supposed to do, but never through direct refusal; rather, she/he procrastinates, dawdles, makes mistakes, etc.

Application activity 3.2



1. What are the three clusters of personality disorders, and which general traits define each cluster?
2. The case study describes a student who avoids social interactions because of fear of criticism but still longs for friendships. Which personality disorder and cluster would you identify? Justify your choice.
3. Assess the potential impact of labelling a student with a personality disorder on their social and academic development.

3.3. Causes and risk factors of personality disorders

Learning activity 3.3



Three students: Balinda, Teta and Cyusa have been referred to the school counsellor due to ongoing social and emotional difficulties: Balinda, 16 years, avoids peers and often believes others are talking about him or trying to harm him. He prefers to stay alone and struggles with trust in relationships. Balinda's parents note that his grandfather had a history of mental health challenges, and Rugamba has always been highly sensitive and cautious. Teta, 15 years old, forms intense friendships but frequently experiences conflicts and sudden emotional outbursts. She sometimes feels abandoned. Teta has experienced inconsistent parenting and witnessed frequent arguments at home. She also experienced emotional neglect during her early childhood. Cyusa, 17 years old, is extremely anxious in social situations, avoids speaking in class, and relies heavily on friends and teachers to make decisions. His family has faced financial instability, and Muligo has grown up in a highly unpredictable environment, moving homes multiple times.

Question: Are the personality challenges experienced by the three students caused by the same factors, or do different causes contribute to each case?

Personality disorders do not have a single known cause. Instead, experts generally agree that these conditions arise from the interaction of **biological, psychological, and environmental** factors throughout development (Pan & Wang, 2024).

3.3.1. Genetic and Biological Factors

Family history and heredity: People with a family history of personality disorders or other mental health conditions have a higher likelihood of developing a personality disorder themselves.

Temperament and inherited traits: Innate temperament (such as high emotional reactivity, impulsivity, or social inhibition) can influence how personality develops and may predispose individuals to certain disorders.

Neurobiological influences: Research indicates that differences in brain structure, function, and neurochemistry (especially in areas related to emotional regulation) are associated with personality disorders.

3.3.2. Early Life Experiences and Environment

Childhood trauma: Experiencing physical, emotional, or sexual abuse, neglect, or harsh or unpredictable caregiving during childhood significantly increases the risk of developing a personality disorder later in life.

Attachment and family dynamics: Insecure attachment patterns, where children do not form stable emotional bonds with caregivers, can disrupt normal personality development and increase vulnerability to disorders.

Chaotic or unstable environment: Family dysfunction, chronic stress, exposure to violence, or inconsistent discipline and support during early years may contribute to maladaptive personality patterns.

Social Risk Factors

Low socioeconomic status, family dysfunction, or chronic exposure to stress may be associated with higher rates of personality disorders.

Application activity 3.3



1. What are the two main categories of factors that contribute to the development of personality disorders?
2. Examine how social risk factors such as low socioeconomic status might interact with biological vulnerabilities to influence personality development.
3. Which risk factor (biological, psychological, or social) do you think is most important in predicting personality disorders? Justify your answer with a reason

3.4. Impact of personality disorders

Learning activity 3.4



Mucyo, a 16-year-old student, has been struggling with intense emotions and unstable relationships. He often feels empty and becomes angry quickly, especially when he perceives that someone has disappointed or abandoned her.

At School, Mucyo finds it difficult to maintain friendships. He has conflicts with peers over small misunderstandings and sometimes reacts with anger or withdrawal. His teachers notice that he struggles to work on group projects, often leaving assignments unfinished or getting frustrated with classmates. His academic performance is inconsistent, sometimes excellent, other times below her ability due to emotional distress. At Home, Mucyo's emotional difficulties also affect her family. He frequently argues with her parents over minor issues and becomes upset when family members set limits or disagree with him. His parents report feeling anxious and unsure about how to respond, sometimes giving in to his demands to avoid conflict. Mucyo feels isolated and misunderstood, which worsens his emotional instability.

1. How do Mucyo's intense emotions and unstable relationships affect his experiences at school and his interactions with teachers and classmates?
2. In what ways do Mucyo's behaviours influence his family life, and how might this affect his emotional wellbeing over time?

Personality disorders can have profound effects not only on the individuals experiencing them but also on their families and society as a whole (Pan & Wang, 2024).

3.4.1. Impact on Individuals

Impact on functioning: Personality disorders affect psychological, emotional, and social functioning, often leading to poor emotional control, relationship problems, and social isolation.

Mental health comorbidity: Avoidant Personality Disorder often co-occurs with other mental health conditions, including depression, anxiety, and substance use disorders.

Education and employment: Personality disorders can disrupt education and employment because individuals may struggle with impulsivity, emotional instability, and workplace relationships.

Risky behaviours: Some disorders, especially antisocial personality disorder, are associated with aggressive behaviour and a higher risk of violent or antisocial actions.

3.4.2. Impact on Families

Emotional strain on families: Personality disorders can create significant emotional and psychological stress for family members due to unpredictable behaviour and frequent conflicts.

Caregiver burden: Caring for someone with a personality disorder may cause emotional exhaustion, frustration, and feelings of helplessness.

Relationship difficulties: Communication problems, intense anger, and fear of abandonment can create tension and weaken trust and stability within the family.

Psychological distress in relatives: Family members such as parents, spouses, and siblings may experience anxiety, depression, and caregiver burden, often worsened by misunderstanding or stigma.

Impact on parenting and family functioning: Personality disorders can disrupt parenting and family stability, potentially affecting children's emotional and psychological development

3.4.3. Impact on Society

Healthcare burden: Personality disorders require long-term treatment and crisis intervention, increasing mental health care costs and resource use.

Crime and public safety: These disorders, particularly antisocial personality disorder, increase the risk of violent behaviour and criminal recidivism.

Economic impact: Severe symptoms can reduce employment and productivity, leading to higher unemployment and increased reliance on social support systems.

Social stigma and discrimination: Personality disorders can lead to negative stereotypes and misunderstandings, discouraging treatment-seeking and limiting social integration.

3.4.4. Impact on school

Impact on Academic Performance: Students may have difficulty concentrating due to emotional instability or anxiety. Rigid thinking patterns can make it hard to adapt to new ideas or instructions.

Impact on Relationships: struggle to form friendships or maintain healthy peer relationships, conflicts with classmates and teachers.

Emotional Difficulties: experience, intense emotions or hypersensitivity, react strongly to criticism,

Impact on Participation and Learning Environment: Fear of judgment may prevent students from participating in discussions or group work.

Application activity 3.4



1. What are the main ways personality disorders can affect an individual's daily functioning
2. Explain the impacts of personality disorders on families and society.
3. Examine how the combination of personal, family, and societal impacts might affect a person's long-term quality of life
4. Imagine a student with emotional instability and frequent conflicts with peers. How might these challenges affect their school performance and social relationships?

Reference

Pan, B., & Wang, W. (2024). Practical implications of ICD-11 personality disorder classifications. *BMC Psychiatry*, 24, 191. <https://doi.org/10.1186/s12888-024-05640-3>

Chow, R. T. S., Yu, R., Geddes, J. R., & Fazel, S. (2024). Personality disorders, violence and antisocial behaviour: Updated systematic review and meta-regression analysis. *The British Journal of Psychiatry*, 227(1), 481–491. <https://doi.org/10.1192/bjp.2024.226>

3.5. Treatment and management approaches of personality disorders

Learning activity 3.5



Uwineza, a 28-year-old, has borderline personality disorder. She experiences intense emotional swings, fears abandonment, and struggles with maintaining relationships. She recently lost her job due to impulsive conflicts at work. Uwineza's family finds it challenging to support her and often feels frustrated and stressed.

Question: Discuss how the family could support Uwineza to improve her emotional regulation, relationships, and work functioning.

Personality disorders often cause significant distress and impairment in daily life. Their treatment typically requires a multidisciplinary approach that combines **self-management strategies**, **family and social support**, and **psychotherapy** (Guillén et al., 2022).

3.5.1. Lifestyle and self-management

Healthy routines (sleep, diet, exercise)

Establishing and maintaining healthy daily routines helps stabilise mood, reduce stress, and support overall brain and body functioning. Regular sleep, balanced nutrition, and Physical activity are linked to improved emotional regulation and better mental well-being.

Stress management (mindfulness, meditation)

Stress management techniques such as mindfulness and meditation help individuals become more aware of their thoughts and emotions without feeling overwhelmed.

Avoidance of substance misuse and risky behaviours

Substance misuse and other high-risk behaviours often co-occur with personality disorders as maladaptive coping strategies. Avoiding such behaviours is crucial because they exacerbate emotional instability and interpersonal conflict.

3.5.2. Family and Social Support

Good family environment

A stable, supportive, and nurturing family environment provides children with consistent emotional support, positive models of conflict resolution, healthy communication, and secure attachment, all of which help them build resilience, emotional regulation, and interpersonal skills (Güngör et al., 2020).

Family therapy

Family therapy involves structured sessions where family members work with mental health professionals to improve communication, resolve conflict, and help family members develop shared strategies for supporting the person more effectively.

3.5.3. Psychotherapy

Psychotherapy is provided by trained mental health professionals with specialised education and licensure in psychological therapy. Using clinical and psychological techniques, psychotherapy helps individuals improve emotional regulation and impulse control, reduce self-destructive or harmful behaviours, enhance interpersonal relationships, increase self-awareness and coping skills, and promote long-term personal growth and social functioning.

Application activity 3.5



1. Explain how different treatment and management approaches for personality disorders work together to complement each other in preventing the onset and managing the symptoms of personality disorders.
2. Reflecting on the importance of a supportive family environment, how would you, as a future caregiver or parent, foster warmth, effective communication, and emotional support in your family to help prevent personality disorders and promote healthy development?

Reference

- Guillén, V., Fonseca-Baeza, S., Fernández-Felipe, I., Botella, C., Baños, R., & Marco, J. H. (2022). *Effectiveness of Family Connections intervention for family members of persons with personality disorders in two different formats: Online vs face-to-face*. *Internet Interventions*, 28, 100532. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.invent.2022.100532>
- Güngör, D., Bornstein, M. H. & Schapiro, S. C. (2020). *The effect of positive childhood experiences on adult personality psychopathology*. *Personality and Individual Differences*, 158, 109862.

3.6. End unit assessment



Knowledge and Understanding

1. Define the term personality disorder.
2. Outline the major classifications (clusters) of personality disorders.
3. Give one real-life example showing how a personality disorder may affect an individual's daily functioning.

Skills

4. Compare two different types of personality disorders in terms of symptoms and causes.

5. Assess the challenges involved in managing personality disorders in society.
6. Design a diagram or chart showing types of personality disorders, their causes, risk factors, and treatment approaches.

Attitudes and Values

7. Describe how you would show empathy toward a person with a personality disorder.
8. Discuss the importance of early diagnosis and treatment of personality disorders.
9. Propose ways to promote awareness and reduce stigma about personality disorders in your school or community.

UNIT 4

INTRODUCTION TO LEARNING Psychology



Key Unit Competence:

Examine the role of initiative, curiosity, and creativity in one's learning.

Learning objectives

By the end of this unit, you should be able to:

Knowledge and understanding

1

- Explain the meaning of learning.
- Identify the main characteristics of learning.
- Identify stages and styles of learning.
- Describe the domains of learning.
- Identify major factors that influence learning,
- Differentiate between internal and external factors influencing learning.
- Explain the role of Initiative, curiosity, and creativity in learning.

Skills

2

- Compare and contrast domains of learning.
- Construct a concept map showing key features of learning.
- Generate original ideas or creative solutions in a learning context.
- Collaborate effectively to produce creative outputs that show understanding of learning processes.
- Analyse examples from daily life where learning principles are evident.

Attitudes and values

3

- Appreciate the importance of continuous learning.
- Demonstrate patience and persistence in progressing through learning stages.
- Adopt a positive attitude toward acquiring new knowledge.
- Recognise the importance of holistic development.
- Appreciate the individual and environmental factors in learning and responsibility for creating a conducive learning environment.

Introduction

The concern of learning Psychology is how individuals acquire, process, and retain knowledge, skills, attitudes, and behaviours. This unit explains how people learn and develop different abilities over time. It helps you understand the meaning and characteristics of learning, and it shows you the stages of learning development as well as the main areas of learning. It also explores the factors that influence learning, including motivation, environment, and individual abilities, as well as different learning styles and individual differences among students. In addition, the unit highlights the role of initiative, curiosity, and creativity in the learning process.

Introductory activity



Two students, Karabo and Ngabo, are in the same class and are taught the same lesson by the same teacher. Karabo enjoys asking questions, participates actively in class discussions, and likes doing practical activities. She quickly understands new concepts and often connects them to real-life situations. Ngabo, on the other hand, prefers to read quietly and learn by observing examples before trying tasks himself. Sometimes he takes longer to understand the lesson, but he performs well when given enough time to practice. Although both students eventually learn the material, they learn in different ways and at different speeds.

Questions:

1. Why do you think Karabo and Ngabo learn differently even though they are in the same class?
2. What factors might influence how each student learns?
3. How can the teacher support both students to learn effectively?

4.1. The meaning and characteristics of learning

Learning activity 4.1



1. Think about a skill you learned recently (for example, riding a bicycle, solving a math problem, using a phone application, etc.). What changes showed that learning had taken place?
2. From your example, what are the main characteristics of learning?

4.1.1. Learning

According to Schunk (2012), learning is defined as a relatively permanent change in behaviour or knowledge that occurs through experience. This means that learning is not simply memorising information for a short time; rather, it involves a lasting change in how a person thinks, feels, or acts.

4.1.2. Learning Psychology

Learning Psychology is a branch of Psychology that studies how individuals acquire, process, retain, and apply knowledge, skills, attitudes, and behaviours through experience, practice and interaction with the environment.

4.1.3. Characteristics of Learning

Learning involves change

Learning always results in some form of change in an individual's behaviour, knowledge, skills, or attitudes.

Learning is relatively permanent

The change produced by learning is usually long lasting rather than temporary. Learning leads to stable improvements in knowledge or skills over time.

Learning occurs through experience and practice

Learning takes place when individuals interact with their environment, practice tasks, or gain experience.

Learning is a continuous process

Learning does not occur only in school; it takes place throughout life. People learn new ideas, skills, and attitudes from childhood to adulthood through daily experiences, education, and social interactions.

Learning involves active participation

Effective learning requires the learner to be actively involved in the process.

Learning can occur in different domains

Learning affects several areas of development, including the cognitive domain (knowledge and thinking), the affective domain (attitudes and emotions), and the psychomotor domain (physical and practical skills).

Application activity 4.1



1. Explain what learning is and how it leads to changes in knowledge, skills, attitudes, or behaviour.
2. Analyse a recent learning activity you did. Which characteristics of learning were most evident, and why?
3. Explain what "learning is relatively permanent." means

Reference

Schunk, D. H. (2012). *Learning theories: An educational perspective* (6th ed.). Pearson. Retrieved from https://www.google.comsearch?q=Schunk%2C+D.+H.+%282012%29.+Learning+theories%3A+An+educational+perspective&sca_esv

4.2. Stages of learning

Learning activity 4.2



1. Do you think people learn a skill all at once or gradually?
2. Why do students often make mistakes when they begin learning something new?
3. After practising a skill many times, what are the changes in the way a person performs it?

Learning is not an instantaneous event but a progressive process that unfolds through several stages as learners develop knowledge and skills (Schallert & Martin, 2003).

Acquisition Stage

The acquisition stage is the initial phase of learning where students begin to understand and acquire new knowledge or skills. At this stage, students learn the subject matter and focus on building basic understanding and accurate performance. Errors are common at this stage, and frequent feedback is essential to help learners adjust and refine their responses.

Fluency Stage

Once the student has acquired the basic skill or knowledge, they move into the fluency stage, where the emphasis shifts to practising for speed, accuracy, and automaticity.

Maintenance Stage

The maintenance stage refers to the student's ability to retain and use the learned knowledge or skill over time, even after direct instruction has ended. At this phase, students can demonstrate consistency in performance without needing constant support or review.

Generalisation Stage

In the generalisation stage, students apply what they have learned to new and varied situations, contexts, or problems beyond the original learning environment.

Adaptation Stage

The final stage, adaptation, involves the student's ability to modify or adapt the learned skills and knowledge to meet novel or complex challenges. Rather than merely applying what is known, students in this stage use their understanding creatively and flexibly to solve unfamiliar problems or to innovate.

Application activity 4.2



1. List the five stages of learning discussed in the lesson.
2. Explain how a student can support himself during the acquisition stage to understand new knowledge or skills

Reference

Schallert, D. L., & Martin, D. B. (2003). *A psychological analysis of what teachers and students do in the language arts classroom*. In J. Flood, D. Lapp, J. R. Squire, & J. M. Jensen (Eds.), *Handbook of research on teaching the English language arts* (pp. 31–45). Mahwah, NJ: Erlbaum.

4.3. Domains of learning

Learning activity 4.3



Your school has decided to start a vegetable garden project to promote healthy eating and environmental awareness. A group of students (Mugabo, Kanyange, and Rugaba) plans and implements the project.

On the first day, Mugabo carefully reads instructions, researches which vegetables grow best in the area, and explains the steps to others.

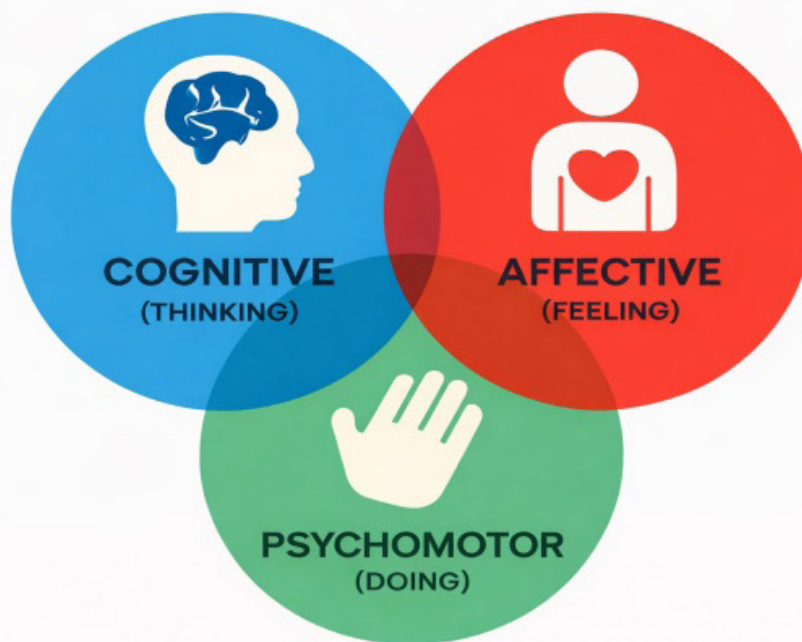
Kanyange shows excitement about the project, encourages teamwork, and reminds others to take care of the plants responsibly. Rugaba actively participates in digging, planting seeds, watering, and handling tools correctly.

Question: Among the three students,

- a) Who is using thinking and knowledge skills?
- b) Who is showing attitudes, feelings, or values?
- c) Who is demonstrating physical or hands-on skills?

The Domains of learning refer to the main categories in which human learning occurs. They describe the different types of skills, knowledge, attitudes, and behaviours that learners develop. Learning theorists such as Benjamin Bloom and his colleagues classified learning into three main domains: cognitive, affective, and psychomotor (Bloom et al., 1956).

THE THREE DOMAINS OF LEARNING



4.3.1. Cognitive Domain (Knowledge and Intellectual Skills)

The cognitive domain focuses on mental abilities and the development of knowledge. It involves thinking, understanding, remembering, problem solving, and reasoning. This domain has different levels, as referred to in Bloom's Taxonomy:

Remembering (recalling facts): This is the lowest level of thinking, where students recall facts, definitions, lists, or previously learned information without necessarily understanding it. It focuses on memory and recognition.

Understanding (explaining ideas): Explaining ideas or concepts in one's own words. At this level, students can interpret, summarise, or describe concepts and show that they understand relationships between ideas.

Applying (using knowledge in practice): Students take what they have learned and use it to solve problems or handle new situations. This shows that learners understand the content well and can apply it beyond memorisation.

Analysing (breaking ideas into parts): At this level, students break information into smaller parts to understand how those parts relate to each other. They identify patterns, causes, motives, or underlying structures.

Evaluating (judging or making decisions): Students assess ideas, methods, or solutions using criteria, evidence, or standards. They justify their opinions and make reasoned decisions.

Creating (producing new ideas): This is the highest level, where students combine knowledge and skills to produce something new and original. They may design, construct, or propose solutions. Examples of learning in the cognitive domain: Memorising formulas, explaining a concept, solving mathematical problems, designing a project or solution

4.3.2. Affective Domain (Attitudes, Values, and Emotions)

The affective domain relates to feelings, attitudes, values, motivations, and emotional responses. It focuses on how individuals react emotionally and how they develop interests, appreciation, and commitment toward certain ideas or activities. Levels of the affective domain include:

Receiving: This is the most basic level, where a student becomes aware of something and is willing to pay attention to it. It does not require deep engagement yet, just openness and attention.

Responding: At this level, students go beyond just listening; they actively engage with the idea or experience. They respond through participation, discussion, or practice.

Valuing: Here, students begin to attach personal value or importance to an idea or behaviour. They start to see it as worthwhile and may show commitment.

Organising: At this level, students compare, relate, and integrate different values into a consistent system. They may resolve conflicts between values and prioritise them.

Characterising: At this highest level, people fully internalise values and consistently use them to guide their behaviour. The student acts in ways that reflect these values across different situations. Examples of learning in the affective domain: Showing respect for others, demonstrating interest in learning, developing positive attitudes toward work, practising ethical behaviour.

4.3.3. Psychomotor Domain (Physical and Motor Skills)

The psychomotor domain involves physical movement, coordination, and the use of motor skills. It focuses on developing the ability to perform tasks that require bodily movement and physical control.

Imitation: This is the entry-level stage of skill acquisition, where learners reproduce a movement or action by watching a demonstration or example. Accuracy may be low at this stage, but it shows awareness and attention to a model.

Manipulation: At this level, students can perform a task correctly with some guidance, hints, or structured instructions. Their accuracy improves, but they may still need some help.

Precision: This stage reflects proficiency and confidence in performing the task. Movements are accurate, well timed, and efficient.

Articulation: The student can integrate multiple skills into a smooth, coordinated performance. Focus is on fluidity, timing, and efficiency, rather than isolated movements.

Naturalisation: This is the highest level of psychomotor mastery. The student can perform complex tasks automatically, efficiently, and accurately, even under pressure. Examples of learning in the psychomotor domain: Writing or drawing, playing a musical instrument, performing laboratory techniques, operating tools or machines.

Application activity 4.3



1. Explain the importance of the psychomotor domain in skill development.
2. Analyse how the three domains of learning complement each other in the learning process.
3. Evaluate how ignoring the affective domain can affect relationships or teamwork in a normal life situation.

Reference

Benjamin Bloom, B. S., Engelhart, M. D., Furst, E. J., Hill, W. H., & David R. Krathwohl (1956). *Taxonomy of Educational Objectives: The Classification of Educational Goals, Handbook I: Cognitive Domain*. New York: Longmans, Green and Co., pp. 7–8

4.4. Factors influencing learning

Learning activity 4.4



Keza is very motivated and enjoys learning. She usually studies at home, where her parents support her and provide learning materials. Her teacher uses different teaching methods such as discussions, group work, and visual aids. The classroom is quiet and well arranged. As a result, Keza performs very well in her studies. Manzi, on the other hand, often comes to school tired because he sleeps late. He has little interest in learning and rarely participates in class. At home, he has no quiet place to study. In class, he sits in a crowded and noisy environment, and sometimes the teacher mainly lectures without using learning materials. Manzi's academic performance is poor.

Questions:

1. What factors help Keza perform well in school?
2. What factors might be causing Manzi to perform poorly?

A variety of factors influence how individuals acquire, process, and retain knowledge. These factors can be broadly categorised into personal, environmental, psychological, and instructional elements that interact to affect a student's performance and engagement (Schunk, 2020).

4.4.1. Student-related factors

These characteristics within the learner influence learning.

Motivation

Motivation is the student's interest or desire to learn. Highly motivated students pay more attention, participate actively, and persist in challenging tasks. Motivation can be intrinsic (learning for personal satisfaction) or extrinsic (learning for rewards such as grades or praise).

Intelligence and ability

Intelligence refers to a student's capacity to understand ideas, solve problems, and apply knowledge. Students with higher cognitive abilities often grasp concepts faster.

Prior knowledge and experience

Learning becomes easier when students can connect new information to what they already know. Previous experiences provide a foundation that helps students interpret and understand new concepts.

Health and physical condition

Good physical and mental health improve concentration and memory. Factors such as fatigue, illness, hunger, or stress can negatively affect a student's ability to focus and learn effectively.

Attitude toward Learning

A positive attitude encourages curiosity, persistence, and engagement, while a negative attitude can lead to disinterest and poor academic performance.

4.4.2. Teacher-related factors

Teaching skills and competence

Teaching skills and competence refer to the teacher's ability to plan, organise, present, and evaluate learning activities effectively. Competent teachers have a strong understanding of the subject matter and are able to explain concepts in a clear and simple way that students can understand.

Teacher's attitude and personality

The teacher's attitude and personality greatly influence students' interest and motivation to learn. A teacher who is friendly, patient, respectful, and enthusiastic creates a welcoming and supportive classroom environment.

Classroom management

When a teacher manages the classroom well, distractions such as noise and conflicts are minimised. This allows students to concentrate on the lesson and participate actively in learning activities.

4.4.3. Environmental factors

The learning environment significantly affects the learning process because it determines the conditions in which students study and interact.

Physical Environment

The physical environment refers to the physical conditions of the classroom or learning space where teaching and learning take place. Factors such as adequate lighting, comfortable seating, quiet place help students feel comfortable and focused during lessons.

Social Environment

The social environment refers to the relationships and interactions among students, teachers, and other people within the learning setting. A positive social environment encourages cooperation, respect, and effective communication among students and teachers.

Home Environment

The home environment also plays an important role in influencing learning. It includes the conditions, attitudes, and support that learners receive from their families at home.

4.4.4. Instructional factors

Instructional factors are elements related to the methods, materials, and structure of teaching that influence how effectively learning takes place. These factors shape how teachers present information to learners and how well learners understand and apply what they learn.

Teaching Methods

Teaching methods refer to the strategies and approaches teachers use to deliver lessons and help students understand concepts. Different teaching methods, such as discussion, demonstration, lecture, group work, and problem-solving activities, influence how learners receive and process information.

Learning Materials and Resources

Learning materials and resources are tools and aids used to support teaching and learning. These include textbooks, charts, diagrams, pictures, models, audiovisual materials, computers, projectors, and other educational technologies.

Curriculum Design

Curriculum design refers to the organisation and planning of what learners are expected to learn at each level of education. A well-designed curriculum clearly outlines learning objectives, subject content, teaching activities, and assessment methods.

Application activity 4.4



1. Explain how motivation influences students' learning.
2. Suggest strategies that show how a learner can effectively use technology to improve academic performance.
3. Assess the impact of a positive home environment on students' success.

4.5. Learning styles and individual differences

Learning activity 4.5



Three students: Umurerwa, Kalinda, and Munyana are learning a new English lesson about comparatives.

Umurerwa understands the lesson better when the teacher uses pictures, charts, and written examples on the board, such as pictures comparing two animals or objects (e.g., "A lion is bigger than a cat."). She enjoys reading sentences and writing notes in her notebook to remember how to form comparatives. Kalinda prefers listening to the teacher's explanations and participating in class discussions. He remembers how to use comparatives when the teacher explains them aloud and when he practices speaking, for example, saying sentences like "My house is bigger than my friend's house." Munyana enjoys practical language activities. She understands the lesson better when the teacher organises role-plays, dialogues, or language games where students compare objects, people, or places using comparative forms.

1. How does Umurerwa prefer to learn the lesson about comparatives?
2. How does Kalinda prefer to learn the lesson?
3. What activities help Munyana understand the lesson better?
4. What do you notice about the different ways the students learn?

4.5.1. Learning styles

Learning styles are simply different approaches or ways of learning. Students learn in different ways, like seeing, hearing and experiencing things (MELISA Kelly & GRACE Fleming):



Visual learning style:

Learners who have a visual learning style learn best by using their sense of sight. These learners often need quiet study time to concentrate effectively. Visual learners also like colours and tend to understand or enjoy charts and other visual representations of information.

Auditory learning style

Learners with an auditory learning style learn best through verbal lectures, discussions, and by talking things through while listening to what others have to say. They often benefit from reading texts aloud and using a tape recorder to review information.

Kinaesthetic learning style

This learning style uses touch. Tactile or kinaesthetic learners learn best through hands-on activities, actively exploring the physical world around them.

Multimodal learning style

These are people with a mixture of learning preferences, such as two or three.

4.5.2. Learning styles and individual differences

Individual differences in daily life and academic study closely connect to learning styles. In everyday life and in school, individuals show different preferences when they try to understand new information.

Knowing their learning style can also help students develop effective study habits and techniques that help them learn more effectively. Moreover, when students use study methods that match their learning style, they become more active and confident in their learning process. This also helps them improve their communication and language skills.

Application activity 4.5



1. How can a student use knowledge of learning styles to improve his or her daily study routine?
2. Which learning style do you think is most effective for studying languages? Explain your opinion.

Reference

- Kelly, M., & Fleming, G. (n.d.). *Learning styles based on the VARK model*. ThoughtCo. <https://www.thoughtco.com>
- https://www.istockphoto.com/vector/learning-styles-with-visual-auditory-read-and-kinaesthetic-outline-diagram-gm2075607979_564870534?searchscope=image%2Cfilm

4.6. Initiative, curiosity, and creativity

Learning activity 4.6



A teacher gives the class a project: "Create something that shows how to keep the environment clean." However, the teacher does not give detailed instructions on what to do or how to start.

In the class, Kamaliza and Mwumvaneza decide to wait quietly, hoping the teacher will explain more. Meanwhile, Kamali starts asking questions like, "Can we work in groups?" and "What materials can we use?" Nyampinga begins suggesting ideas such as drawing posters and writing short messages about keeping the environment clean. Aline, on the other hand, proposes creating a short skit to act out in front of the class. Soon, a few other students join them, sharing ideas and trying different approaches.

Question: How can taking action, asking questions, and thinking of new ideas help students learn new things?

4.6.1. Initiative

Initiative shows the ability to act resourcefully and to work without always waiting for instructions. It can also mean a personal quality that shows a willingness to get things done and take responsibility (Fiveable, 2025)

Importance of initiative in learning

With initiative, students take action without waiting to be asked or told, solve problems that others may not have noticed, needed solving, go out of their way to continue learning and growing, they find what they need to know, and they take advantage of opportunities that others pass by.

The initiative enables students to be resourceful. It helps students have resilience and determination. People who show initiative demonstrate that they can think for themselves and act when necessary (meaning using their head and having the drive to achieve).

4.6.2. Curiosity

Curiosity reflects a natural interest that humans show in the world around them. It also expresses a strong desire to know or learn something. A curious person has a strong desire to learn or know something. Cultural context plays a large part in nurturing children's curiosity.

Importance of curiosity in learning

Curiosity is a key ingredient of learning, as it not only leads to knowledge but also helps individuals make meaningful connections between different pieces of information. In the context of language learning, curiosity plays an especially important role by increasing learner engagement and motivation. When learners are curious, their brains become more prepared to absorb new information, making the learning process more enjoyable, rewarding, and effective.

"Curiosity connects closely to success because it drives students to explore the unknown, make discoveries, build relationships, uncover opportunities, and grow personally. This natural drive to explore often results in better academic achievement. In children, curiosity also prevents boredom, as it encourages them to actively investigate their surroundings and create their own activities instead of passively waiting for something to engage them.

Tips to promote curiosity in learning

- Proceed with activities which require predicting, guessing, solving problems, or exploring big questions. -Take enough time to investigate and tinker.
- Learn through trial and error, attempting to find a solution before the teacher does.
- Model curiosity (curiosity can be refined through observation and practice).

4.6.3. Creativity

Creativity refers to the ability to generate original and valuable ideas, products, or solutions that are new and useful. It involves thinking in novel ways, making unique connections, and approaching problems from different perspectives (Sternberg & Lubart).

Importance of creativity in learning

Creativity provides students with a meaningful space to express their thoughts and feelings while exploring their inner world. Through creative activities, students develop greater self-awareness and learn how to cope with stress in healthy ways. It engages all their senses, allowing them to create new knowledge and experiences that did not exist before, making learning more dynamic and personal.

In addition, creativity enables individuals to generate innovative ideas and gives them the freedom to explore their surroundings and learn from them. It helps students synthesise information, bringing joy and deeper meaning to their educational experience. By encouraging creativity, learners also develop higher-order cognitive skills such as problem-solving, critical thinking, and the ability to make connections across different subjects.

Common characteristics of a creative person

Some common characteristics of a creative person include the following:

Flexible: Flexibility brings the willingness of creative people to try new ideas and experiences. Flexibility also enables creative people to change their minds about ideas, which makes them more willing to admit when they are wrong.

Playful: Creative people are willing to play with various ideas until they find the right one.

Open-minded: An open-minded person is willing to hear and try new ideas. When collaborating with others, creative people want to hear all the possibilities and explore them further.

Sensitive: Sensitive people are more approachable to others and willing to listen to their thoughts or feelings.

Independent: Working independently allows creative people to embrace their personal freedom. They can make their own decisions on how to do things, without instruction or demands from others.

Intuition: An intuitive person makes decisions based on feelings. Creative people trust in themselves to follow their hearts.

Application activity 4.6



1. Explain two ways to promote curiosity in learning
2. Assess whether a student can be creative without being curious. Support your answer with examples
3. Give an example of a situation where a student shows initiative in completing a learning task.

Reference

Fiveable Content Team. (2025, September). Initiative. Fiveable. <https://fiveable.me/key-terms/curriculum-development/initiative>

Sternberg, R. J., & Lubart, T. I. (1999). The concept of creativity: Prospects and paradigms. In R. J. Sternberg (Ed.), Handbook of creativity (pp 5). Cambridge University Press.

4.7. Application of learning Psychology in real life

Learning activity 4.7



Umurisa is a team leader at a retail store. A new employee, Murwanashyaka, has just joined and needs to learn how to operate the cash register, handle customer complaints, and manage stock. Umurisa demonstrates each task systematically and lets Murwanashyaka try it himself, giving feedback when needed. She breaks tasks into small parts so Murwanashyaka is not overwhelmed and can master each step before moving to the next.

She asks Murwanashyaka questions about what he learned to make sure he understands the tasks. James takes notes and practices tasks repeatedly until he feels confident.

Questions:

1. What learning strategies did Umurisa use to help Murwanashyaka learn?
2. How did Murwanashyaka apply these strategies to remember and perform tasks?
3. Can you think of a similar situation at work or in everyday life where learning Psychology can help?

Learning Psychology studies how people acquire, process, and retain knowledge, and its principles help in various real-life contexts to improve education, personal growth, and everyday problem-solving.



Learning Psychology: Applications in education and workplace training

Education and classroom learning

Educators most often apply learning Psychology in education to improve teaching and learning objectives.

Workplace and professional development

Workplaces apply learning Psychology to strengthen employee training, improve performance, and develop skills.

Personal development and self-Learning

Learning Psychology helps individuals improve personal learning habits and develop skills outside formal education.

Parenting and child development

Parents use principles of learning Psychology to guide children's behaviour and encourage skill development.

Everyday problem solving and decision-making

Learning Psychology is applied in daily life when people solve problems, make decisions, or adapt to new situations.

Health and Lifestyle Applications

People use learning Psychology to promote healthy behaviours and encourage lifestyle changes.

Application activity 4.7



1. Describe the role of learning Psychology in personal development and self-learning
2. Assess whether parenting would be less effective without applying learning Psychology principles. Give examples

4.8. End unit assessment



Knowledge and Understanding

1. List three main characteristics of learning.
2. What does the term "domains of learning" mean?
3. Describe the difference between internal and external factors influencing learning.
4. Explain the role of initiative, curiosity, and creativity in the learning process.

Skills

5. Analyse a scenario from school where a student's curiosity and creativity helped them learn a new concept.
6. Evaluate the effectiveness of a learning strategy you have used in the past.
7. Generate an original idea or solution to make learning more engaging for your peers.

Attitudes and Values

8. Discuss how individual and environmental factors affect your motivation to learn.
9. Assess your responsibility in creating a conducive learning environment in your class.
10. Propose ways to cultivate curiosity and creativity in yourself and others to enhance learning objectives.

UNIT 5

THEORIES OF LEARNING



Key Unit Competence:

Provide opinions on the underlying theories of learning

Learning objectives

By the end of this unit, you should be able to:

1 Knowledge and understanding

- Define key terms related to theories of learning.
- Describe the main ideas and principles of behaviourism, cognitivism, social learning, and connectivism.
- State the implications of different theories of learning in an individual's daily life.
- Identify similarities and differences among the four learning theories.

2 Skills

- Compare and contrast theories of learning
- Create scenarios which reflect theories of learning in daily life situations.
- Create a visual tool to represent relationships among learning theories.
- Communicate and justify their perspectives on which learning theory best supports language learning;

3 Attitudes and values

- Appreciate the importance of understanding learning theories for effective personal development.
- Display confidence in judging the merits of conflicting theories.
- Respect classmates' opinions and experiences related to different learning styles.

Introduction

Psychologists have developed different theories of learning to explain how people learn, how knowledge is processed, and how behaviour changes through experience. By studying these theories, you will understand the different perspectives on learning and how these perspectives influence teaching methods, learning strategies, and personal development. This unit covers the main concepts and principles of several learning theories. It begins with key terms related to learning theories, explores important learning theories: Behaviourism learning theory, Cognitive learning theory, Social learning theory, and Connectivism learning theory. Through this unit, you will develop a deeper understanding of how learning occurs and how different theories contribute to effective teaching and learning practices.

Introductory activity



In a secondary school, a teacher introduced a new science topic and observed that students learned the concept in different ways. First, the teacher explained the topic and gave students exercises. When students answered correctly, the teacher praised them and gave small rewards such as extra points. This motivated students to repeat the correct responses. Next, another group of students focused on understanding the lesson by thinking carefully about the explanation. They connected the new information with previous knowledge and organised their ideas using diagrams and summaries in their notebooks. In another activity, students worked in groups to conduct a small experiment.

They discussed their observations, shared ideas, and built their understanding of the concept through collaboration. **Finally**, some students searched for additional explanations on the internet. They watched educational videos, read online materials, and shared useful links with classmates through a messaging group.

Questions

1. Which example in the case study shows learning through rewards and reinforcement? What does this suggest about how learning occurs?
2. Identify the situation where students used thinking, memory, and connecting new information with previous knowledge.
3. Which activity shows students constructing knowledge through discussion and collaboration? How did this help them understand the topic?
4. In the last situation, how did students use technology and online resources to learn?
5. Based on this case study, why is it important to understand different theories of learning?

5.1. Key terms related to theories of learning

Learning activity 5.1



A student named Maria attends four different lessons in one day, and each teacher uses a different approach: In the first class, the teacher gives rewards (stickers) for correct answers and corrects wrong answers immediately. Students repeat exercises until they get them right. In the second class, the teacher asks students to solve a problem based on what they already know and encourages discussion and discovery. In the third class, students use computers and the internet to research a topic, watch videos, and collaborate with others online. In the fourth class, the teacher explains concepts systematically, uses diagrams, and asks students to think, remember, and solve problems.

Questions:

1. How are the students learning in each situation?
2. Do you think these learning styles are based on different ideas about how people learn?

Theory: One or more ideas that explain how or why something happens. The set of general principles that a particular subject is based on. Learning theories are conceptual frameworks that describe how knowledge is absorbed, processed, and retained during the learning process (Schunk, 2012, pp. 1–2).

Behaviourism: “Behaviourism explains human and animal behaviour through conditioning rather than thoughts or feelings, and it treats behavioural disorders by changing behaviour patterns

Constructivism: The active processing of new information in the context of prior learning and the student’s readiness to learn.

Connectivism: Connectivism is a learning theory that explains how learning occurs through networks and connections, especially in the digital age. It emphasises that learners gain knowledge by connecting with information sources such as people, technology, and online resources.

Cognitivism: Cognitivism is a learning theory that focuses on the mental processes involved in learning, such as thinking, memory, understanding, and problem-solving. It explains how learners process, organise, and store information in their minds.

Schemata: Schemata (plural of schema) are mental structures or frameworks that help people organise and interpret information. They allow learners to connect new knowledge with what they already know.

Stimulus: A stimulus is any event, object, or situation that triggers a reaction or response from a person. In learning, it refers to something that encourages or influences a learner to act or respond.

Response: A response is the reaction or behaviour that occurs after a stimulus. It is how a learner reacts to a particular situation, instruction, or stimulus.

Application activity 5.1



1. Compare behaviourism and cognitivism in terms of how learning occurs.
2. Do you think connectivism is important for modern education? Justify your answer.
3. Explain the interaction between stimulus and response.

Reference

Schunk, D. H. (2012). *Learning theories: An educational perspective (6th ed.)*. Boston, MA: Pearson Education. pp. 1–2.

5.2. Behaviourist learning theory

Learning activity 5.2



A customer sends a letter to the company expressing appreciation for the excellent service provided by a particular employee. During the weekly staff meeting, the manager reads the letter aloud and publicly praises the employee for the good work. As a reward for the positive behaviour, the manager gives the employee a bonus of 50,000 RWF.

The manager explains that giving the bonus to the employee encourages him or her to continue providing excellent customer service and to motivate other employees to demonstrate similar behaviour in the future.

Question: Why do you think the boss praises the employee? Is this have an impact on employees' performance?

5.2.1. Behaviourism

Behaviourism, also known as behavioural Psychology, is a theory of learning that states people learn all behaviours through interaction with the environment in a process called conditioning. Thus, behaviour is simply a response to environmental stimuli. Behaviourism is only concerned with observable stimulus-response behaviours, as they can be studied in a systematic and observable manner (McLeod, S., 2025)

5.2.2. Thorndike and Trial-and-error learning

Edward Lee Thorndike proposed trial-and-error learning. It explains that learning occurs through repeated attempts where individuals try different responses until they find the correct or satisfying one.

Thorndike placed a hungry cat in a puzzle box where it had to pull a loop to open the door and reach the fish outside. Initially, the cat made many unsuccessful attempts but eventually pulled the loop. With repeated trials, the cat learned quickly, taking less time to escape each time.

Thorndike noticed that when an animal found itself in a problem situation it had encountered before, it was more likely to perform the same action that had earlier brought the desired reward. The reward of escaping the box strengthened the association between the stimulus (the subject placed in a closed box) and an appropriate action. Thorndike concluded that rewards act to strengthen stimulus-response associations. This basic principle he applied to humans by claiming that humans develop a myriad of stimulus-response associations.



5.2.3. Criticism of Behaviourism

Behaviourism is unbelievably simple in its assumption that a single mechanism, like conditioning, is responsible for learning. Some of the criticism of behaviourism relates to the following:

Behaviourism views learning as something that happens to a person, treating the learner as passive. However, learners are active both mentally and physically when engaged in the learning process.

It also fails to account for all types of learning because it ignores what happens in the mind. Mental processes are essential for understanding learning, especially in cases like how young children recognise and develop new language patterns.

5.2.4. Applications of behavioural learning in real-life situations

Behavioural learning theory helps educators and leaders encourage positive workplace behaviours by understanding how individuals learn:

People learn how to act through their interactions with others in their environment, shaping behaviour over time. Understanding how people learn can improve how you interact with customers and co-workers, while also supporting your career growth. In the workplace, managers can apply behavioural learning principles to increase employee engagement, enhance performance, and guide less engaged employees toward positive change.

The key is to create the right environment by using a “conditioned stimulus,” such as rewards that encourage desired behaviours. Continuous learning is also essential for business growth and innovation. By introducing self-directed learning, active as well as social learning techniques, teams can develop skills more effectively and achieve greater success.

5.2.5. How to incorporate positive behavioural learning techniques in the workplace

When training or introducing new programs, organisations can use engaging methods such as videos that demonstrate desired behaviours enjoyably. Role-play is also effective, as it allows individuals to experience different perspectives, understand the consequences of actions, and develop empathy in realistic situations. Inviting guest lecturers or respected industry leaders can further encourage positive behaviour, as employees are more likely to learn from and imitate people they admire.

Repetition is another key strategy, helping to reinforce desired behaviours through regular practice, such as monthly training sessions or self-guided exercises with rewards. In addition, regular reviews and assessments of employee performance are important for tracking progress and helping individuals understand their development and areas for improvement.

Application activity 5.2



1. Give an example of positive reinforcement in a family context and explain how it works
2. Do you think rewards and punishments are the best ways to change behaviour at work? Explain your reasoning
3. Analyse how a bank manager could use operant conditioning to improve teamwork and identify which type of reinforcement would be most effective
4. What is a “conditioned stimulus” in the context of behavioural learning at work?

Reference

McLeod, S. (2025). *Behaviourism in Psychology*. Simply Psychology. Retrieved from <https://www.simplyPsychology.org/behaviorism.html>

5.3. Cognitive learning theory

Learning activity 5.3

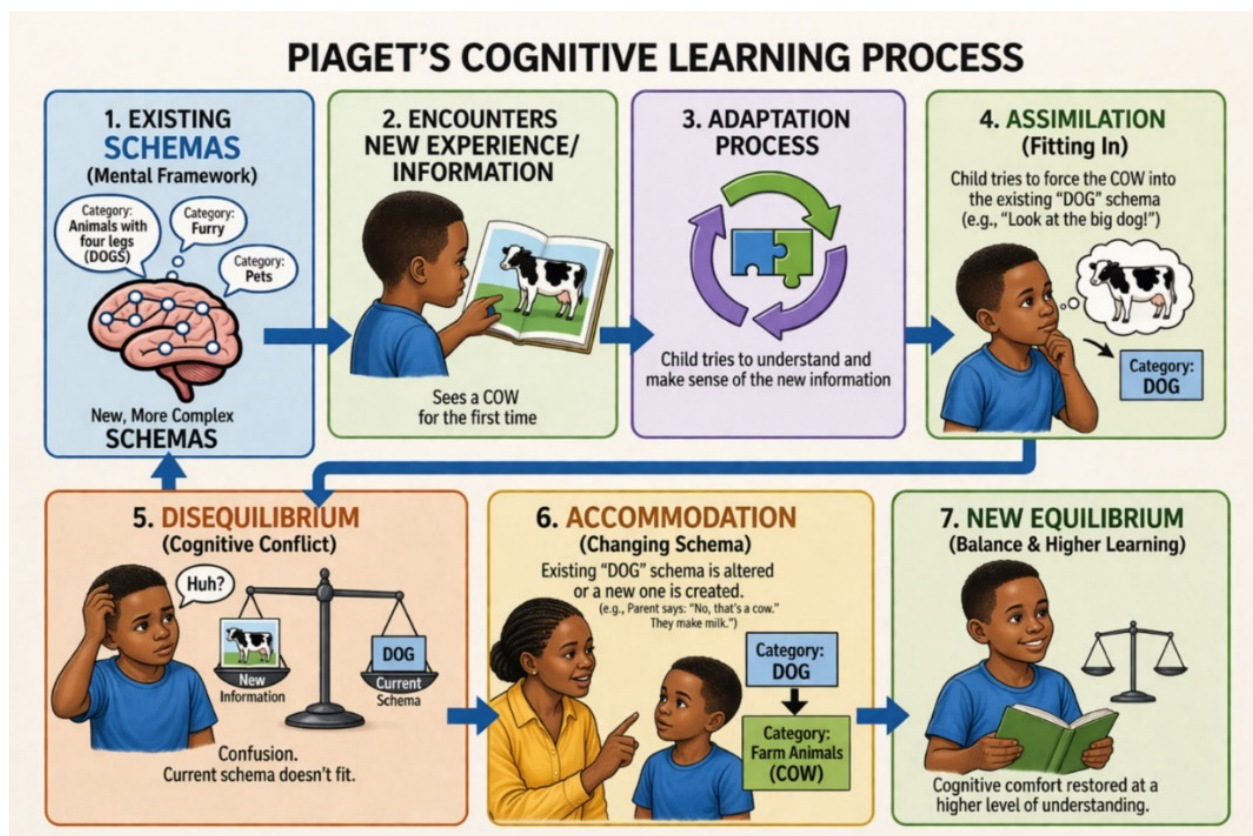


Uwase and Kabandana are writing a short story for their English class. Uwase uses her past knowledge of grammar, vocabulary, and storytelling to plan and organise her story carefully, finishing efficiently with few mistakes. Kabandana writes randomly without using prior knowledge, struggles with revisions, and has to rewrite several parts.

1. How did Uwase use her previous English lessons to write her new story?
2. What differences do you notice between Uwase's and Kabandana's approaches to learning?

5.3.1. Description of cognitive learning theory

Cognitive learning theory focuses on the mental processes involved in learning, such as thinking, memory, problem solving, and understanding. Unlike behaviourism, which emphasises observable behaviours, cognitive theory emphasises how learners actively process information, organise knowledge, and connect new information to what they already know. Learning functions as an internal process, where understanding and comprehension are central. Strategies like using prior knowledge, organising information, and reflecting on experiences are key to effective cognitive learning.



5.3.2. Accommodation and assimilation

In cognitive learning theory, **assimilation** is how learners incorporate new experiences into existing knowledge structures. It happens naturally when new information fits with what the learner already knows, allowing them to understand, categorise, and make sense of their experiences efficiently. Example: A child who knows domestic cats sees a new breed and classifies it as a "cat" using existing knowledge. This refers to assimilation.

Accommodation is the cognitive process in which a learner modifies or changes existing mental structures (schemas) to incorporate new information that does not fit into current knowledge. Unlike assimilation, which adds new information to existing schemas without changing them, accommodation requires adapting or reorganising thinking to understand the new experience. Example: The child sees a tiger, which does not fit their “cat” schema, so they create a new category for “wild cats”. This refers to accommodation.

Equilibrium

In cognitive learning theory, equilibrium is the state of cognitive balance in which a learner’s existing knowledge (schemas) can adequately explain new experiences. It occurs when learners can understand and make sense of incoming information without confusion or conflict. Equilibrium is the goal of learning, achieved when assimilation and accommodation are effectively balanced.

A schema: A schema is a mental framework or structure that organises knowledge, concepts, and experiences. Schemas help learners interpret, process, and store new information by providing a context or pattern to fit into it. They are like “mental templates” that allow us to make sense of the world efficiently (Ormrod, 2020).

5.3.3. Benefits of Cognitive Learning

The following are the major positive effects of cognitive learning:

- **Enhances learning:** Cognitive learning theory supports lifelong learning. Learners can build upon previous ideas and apply new concepts to the knowledge they already have.
- **Boosts confidence:** As learners gain a deeper understanding of new topics and skills, they become more confident in approaching assignments, exams, and classroom discussions.
- **Enhances Comprehension:** Cognitive learning improves learners’ ability to understand new information. They can develop a deeper grasp of learning materials and retain knowledge more effectively.
- **Improves problem-solving skills:** By learning how to learn effectively, learners develop problem-solving skills they can apply when facing challenging academic tasks or real-life situations. **Helps learn new things faster:** Through experience, learners recycle and use learning methods that worked previously. This helps them learn new material more quickly because they already know effective strategies. **Teaches concept formation:** Cognitive learning helps learners form and organise concepts, making it easier to perceive and interpret information. This can boost creativity and lead to innovative ideas in school projects.

5.3.4. Application of cognitive learning theory in daily life

Teachers and schools can apply cognitive learning concepts to produce better outcomes in classrooms. Some cognitivist-informed strategies might include:

- Surveying learners about their prior knowledge of a subject.
- Implementing self-paced programs that allow learners to progress according to their abilities.

- Providing opportunities for learners to ask questions and discuss with one another.
- Allowing learners to share feedback on how lessons or school programs can be improved.
- Incorporating learners' input through surveys or Q&A sessions to personalise learning. This emphasises students' individual knowledge, helping them connect what they already know to what they need to learn.

Application activity 5.3



1. Explain the difference between Assimilation and Accommodation.
2. Evaluate the importance of cognitive learning theory in improving learners' understanding and problem-solving skills.
3. Propose two ways teachers can apply cognitive learning theory in daily classroom practice to improve learning objectives.
4. Give one example from daily life showing how you can use assimilation to understand new information.
5. Describe the meaning of Equilibrium in the learning process.

Reference

Ormrod, J. E. (2020). *Educational Psychology: Developing learners (10th ed.)*. Pearson Education. pp. 165–166.

5.4. Social Learning Theory

Learning activity 5.4



In Senior Five (5), Language Pathways, students are learning how to do presentations in English class. During the lesson, the teacher asks Umwari to present her work in front of the class. Umwari speaks clearly, uses gestures, and maintains eye contact. After her presentation, the teacher praised her and highlighted what she did well. As the lesson continues, other students such as Mbanda, Gisubizo, and Rurangwa begin to present. Mbanda tries to copy Umwari's confidence and speaking style. Gisubizo also imitates her gestures and eye contact. Rurangwa, who was initially shy, becomes more confident after watching Umwari and seeing her receive praise. By the end of the lesson, many students had improved their presentations by observing and imitating Umwari's behaviour.

Questions

1. How did Mbanda, Gisubizo, and Rurangwa learn from Umwari?
2. Why did Rurangwa become more confident after watching Umwari?

Social learning theory is also known as **observational learning, modelling, or imitation**. ALBERT BANDURA developed it. It examines how people learn by observing models and imitating the behaviours of others. It mainly helps in the acquisition of language and behaviour (Bandura, 1977, pp. 22–28).

5.4.1. Phases of observational learning

Attention phase: The first process in social learning is paying attention to the model. Unless students pay attention to modelled events, they cannot learn much from them.

Retention phase: It involves symbolic coding, organising received information, focusing attention, and rehearsing.

Reproduction: After attending to and retaining modelled behaviour, the observer is ready to produce the behaviour.

5.4.2. Principles of social learning

Direct reinforcement: It is provided by the external environment; for example, in a classroom if a teacher shows how to calculate a number in mathematics and a student does it as required, the teacher may praise or reward the student; hence, direct reinforcement.

Vicarious learning: This refers to learning by observing other people's successes and failures rather than experiencing them directly.

Modelling: In modelling, a person called the model demonstrates a behaviour, and another person observes that behaviour and may imitate it. The model can be a teacher, parent, peer, or even a character in media.

5.4.3. Implications of social learning in real-life situations

Vicarious learning emphasises that individuals can learn by observing others. Learning through modelling or imitation can introduce new behaviours or change existing ones, which is why parents, teachers, and other influential figures should consistently demonstrate positive and exemplary behaviour.

In the workplace, employees often develop professional habits, teamwork, and communication skills by observing experienced colleagues or leaders. Managers who model a strong work ethic can encourage similar behaviour in others.

Likewise, people imitate behaviours seen in media such as television, movies, or social media, where positive role models can promote good behaviour, while negative ones may lead to undesirable actions.

Application activity 5.4



1. Outline the three main phases of observational learning
2. Explain the difference between direct reinforcement and vicarious learning with an example.
3. Analyse why employees in a workplace may adopt positive or negative behaviours by observing their colleagues or managers.

4. Evaluate the impact of media on the behaviour of young people. Should role models in media be responsible for promoting positive behaviours?

Reference

Bandura, A. (1977). *Social learning theory*. Prentice-Hall. pp. 22–28.

5.5. Connectivism learning theory

Learning activity 5.5



Gasaro is a secondary school student in Nyamagabe District. In her English class, she has been assigned to learn about irregular verbs, but her teacher provides only a brief introduction and no detailed notes. Instead of relying on a single textbook, Gasaro decides to explore different ways to understand the topic:

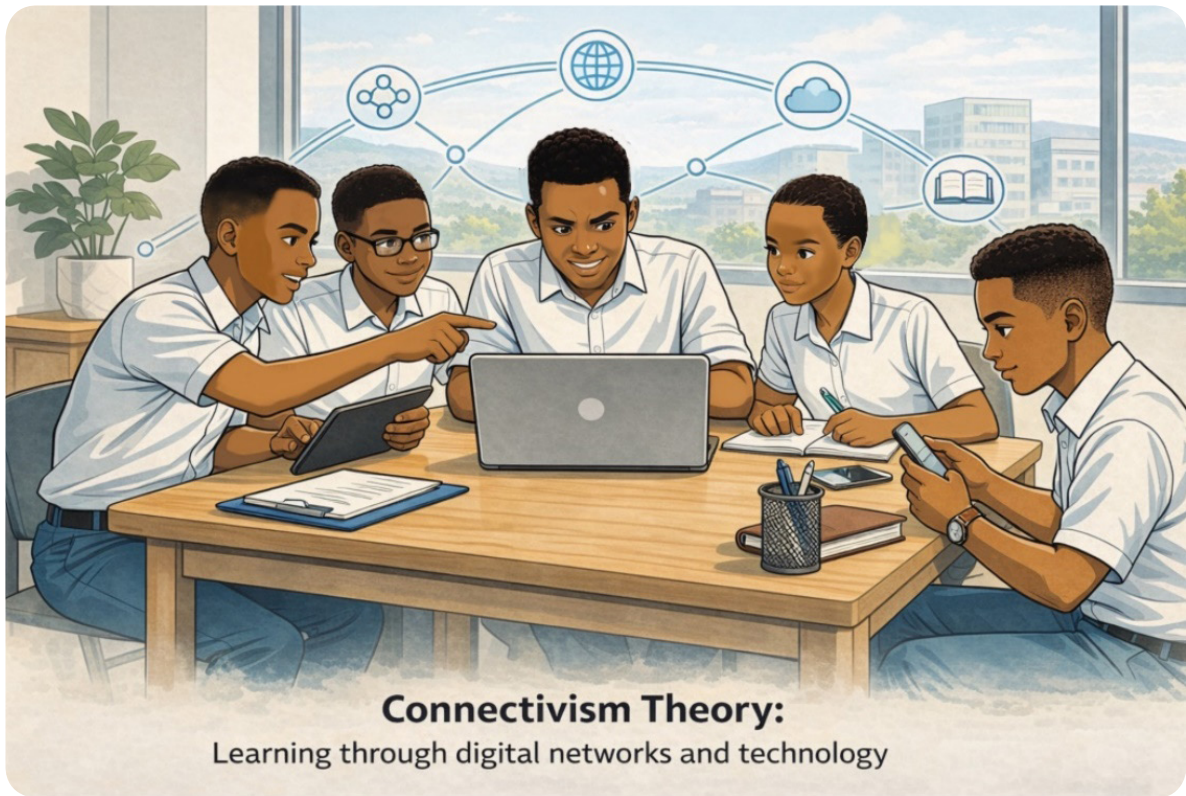
- She joins online communities on WhatsApp platforms where she asks questions and practices using irregular verbs with other students
- She follows English teachers who conduct lessons on verb forms, pronunciation, and usage on YouTube
- She uses AI tools like ChatGPT to practice sentences, check her answers, and get explanations.

Over time, Aline becomes more confident in using irregular verbs correctly in speaking and writing. She realises that learning is not just about memorising verb lists, but about connecting with people, digital tools, and different sources of knowledge.

1. What different sources did Gasaro use to learn irregular verbs?
2. How do these connections help her understand the lesson better?

5.5.1. Description of Connectivism Learning Theory

Connectivism is a new learning theory that proposes that students combine their thoughts, theories, and general knowledge in a useful way. It recognises that technology is an important part of the learning process and that our constant connectivity allows us to make choices about our learning. It also encourages group collaboration and discussion, allowing for different points of view and perspectives when making decisions, solving problems, and making sense of information. Connectivism encourages learning that occurs outside of an individual, such as via social media, online networks, blogs, or information databases (Akyol & Garrison, 2008).



5.5.2. Principles of Connectivism

Connectivism proposes that technology is changing what, how, and where we learn, building on previously established theories. Siemens and Downes identified eight connectivist principles in their research.

- Learning and knowledge are founded on a diversity of viewpoints. Perspectives from various sources broaden our understanding.
- Learning is a connecting process. When we form relationships with colleagues, we expose ourselves to new skills, thoughts, and ideas that we might not have had access to otherwise.
- Non-human appliances may be capable of learning. Learners may save information digitally, such as in an app, a social media post, or a video. Similarly, a learning community may keep information in a database or forum.
- The ability to learn more is more important than what is currently known. "Our ability to learn what we need for tomorrow is more important than what we know today," Siemens says.
- To facilitate continuous learning, connections must be nurtured and maintained. Collaborative social interaction connects people and creates a long-term learning environment.
- A key skill is the ability to see connections between fields, ideas, and concepts. We must learn how to construct a bridge to connect points A and B. That bridge is a new learning opportunity in and of itself.
- The goal of all Connectivist Learning is to provide accurate, up-to-date knowledge. Our understandings are constantly reinforced and updated when we work together.

- Making decisions is a learning process in and of itself. What we know today may not be the case tomorrow. If the goal of connectivism is to provide up-to-date information, we must accept that our knowledge will need to evolve as new understandings emerge.

5.5.3. Application of Connectivism

Because connectivism is heavily reliant on technology, the first step in developing a connectivist classroom is to increase opportunities for digital learning. Here are some more ideas for incorporating connectivism into the classroom:

Social networking sites

Connectivism can be implemented in the classroom by using social media. A class Twitter account, for example, can be used to share information, engage in discussion, or announce homework assignments.

Gamification

Gamification is the use of game elements in education to make learning more engaging and interactive. When viewed through the lens of connectivism, gamification becomes more than just fun; it becomes a powerful way to support networked, connected learning. Teachers can monitor students' progress, and students can earn "points" for completing lessons.

Simulations

Simulations are learning activities that imitate real-life situations, allowing learners to practice skills and make decisions in a safe, interactive environment.

Simulations recreate real scenarios, and students experience tasks as if they were in real life.

Tips and recommendations while using Connectivism Learning

- While connectivism is highly relevant in the digital age, it also has some limitations, and the following are some tips to make it effective:
- Consistent internet access and a device ready for learning activities.
- Learn how to navigate online platforms, apps, and learning networks effectively.
- Check the credibility of sources before using them. Focus on trusted websites, verified experts, and peer-reviewed materials.
- Participate actively in discussions, collaborations, and online activities.
- Compare information from multiple sources before accepting it.
- Collaborate with classmates or join study groups to validate information and gain support.

Application activity 5.5



1. Explain why learning in connectivism is a "networked process."
2. Why is it important to check the reliability of information on social media before using it for learning?
3. Compare traditional classroom learning with connectivism learning. What are the advantages and disadvantages of each?

Reference

Akyol, Z., & Garrison, D. R. (2008). *Connectivism: Learning theory of the future or vestige of the past? The International Review of Research in Open and Distance Learning*, 9(3). <http://www.irrodl.org/index.php/irrodl/article/view/523/1103>

5.6. End unit assessment



Knowledge and understanding

1. State one implication of each learning theory in your daily life.
2. Describe the main principles of cognitivism and explain how it is different from behaviourism.
3. Summarise social learning theory and provide an example of how people learn by observation.
4. Describe connectivism and its relevance in the digital age.

Skills

5. Create a real-life scenario where behaviourism could be applied to teach a new skill.
6. Choose one learning theory that you believe Best supports language learning. Justify your choice with reasons.
7. Develop a scenario that illustrates social learning in a classroom or workplace setting.

Attitudes and Values

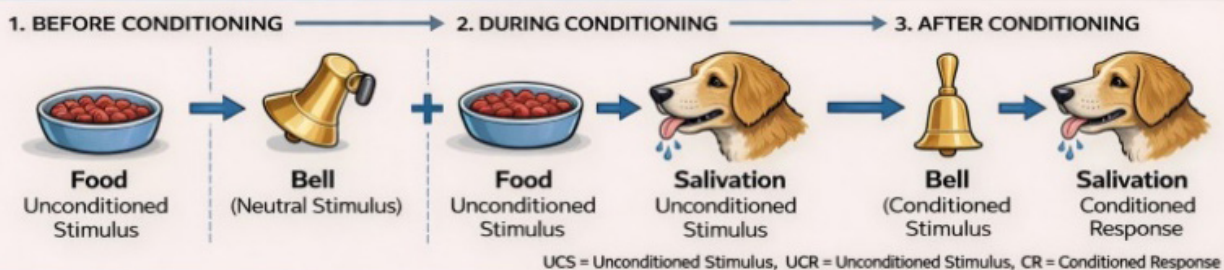
8. Explain why understanding learning theories is important for your personal development.
9. Explain which theory of learning do you consider the most effective?
10. Evaluate how respecting classmates' perspectives on different learning styles can improve collaborative learning.

UNIT 6

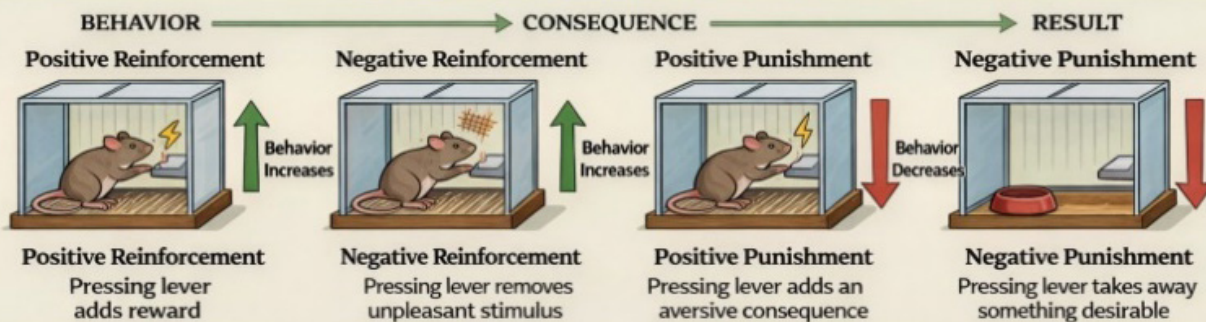
TYPES OF BEHAVIOURAL LEARNING

TYPES OF BEHAVIORAL LEARNING

CLASSICAL CONDITIONING



OPERANT CONDITIONING



OPERANT CONDITIONING



Key Unit Competence:

Compare and contrast types of behavioural learning

Learning objectives

By the end of this unit, you should be able to:

Knowledge and understanding

1

- Define behavioural learning and explain its basic principles.
- Identify the main types of behavioural learning
- Describe the key points of different types of behavioural learning
- Explain how conditioning helps people learn and maintain behaviour.

- Distinguish between positive reinforcement and positive punishment.
- Identify real-life examples that illustrate each type of behaviourist learning.
- State the implications of different types of learning in an individual's daily life

Skills

2

- Compare and contrast types of learning.
- Create scenarios which reflect types of learning in daily life situations.
- Illustrate the process of classical or operant conditioning using real-life cases.
- Design simple behaviour modification plans based on behaviourist principles.

Attitudes and values

3

- Appreciate the role of environment and experience in shaping behaviour.
- Show appreciation for the usefulness of behavioural learning in improving human and social behaviour.
- Demonstrate open-mindedness toward applying behaviourist strategies in different life contexts.
- Develop a positive attitude toward self-discipline and personal behaviour change.

Introduction

Learning is a fundamental process that shapes how individuals behave, think, and interact with their environment. One important way to understand learning is through behavioural learning, which focuses on how external stimuli and responses influence behaviour. This unit introduces you to the concept of behavioural learning and shows how experience helps people acquire, modify, and reinforce behaviours. It explores two major types of behavioural learning: classical conditioning and operant conditioning. In addition, the unit highlights practical strategies for applying behavioural learning in everyday life.

Introductory activity



Murashi is a secondary school student who recently changed his study habits. Every time he finishes his homework on time, his parents allow him to watch his favourite TV show. After a few weeks, Murashi starts completing his homework earlier without reminders.

At school, Murashi's teacher sometimes praises students who answer questions correctly. Murashi notices that when teachers praise his classmates, they become more active in class and try harder to participate.

Meanwhile, Murashi has a younger brother who is afraid of dogs. One day, a dog barked loudly at him, and since then, he cries or runs away whenever he sees any dog, even if it is quiet and friendly.

1. Which example shows learning through reward? Explain.
2. How did Murashi's brother develop fear of dogs?

6.1. Understanding behavioural learning

Learning activity 6.1



Describe a real-life situation where your behaviour changed because of a reward or a punishment. Please explain the situation in detail, including what the reward or punishment was, how you reacted to it, and how it influenced your future behaviour.

Behavioural learning, also known as behaviourism, is a theory that explains learning in terms of observable and measurable changes in behaviour. It emphasises that learning occurs when an individual responds to stimuli from the environment, rather than focusing on internal mental processes such as thoughts or feelings. In this view, the environment shapes behaviour through interaction, where a stimulus leads to a response (Woolfolk, 2016). Over time, repeated associations between stimuli and responses help individuals acquire new behaviours or modify existing ones.

Behavioural learning suggests that experience plays a key role in shaping behaviour through processes such as reinforcement and punishment. When a positive outcome (reward) follows a behaviour, people are more likely to repeat a behaviour when it brings positive consequences, whereas negative consequences reduce the likelihood of that behaviour occurring again. This means that learning is not just about acquiring knowledge, but about forming habits and patterns of behaviour based on experiences. As a result, behavioural learning is widely applied in real-life situations such as education, parenting, and training, where desired behaviours are encouraged, and undesirable ones are discouraged.

Application activity 6.1



1. Assess how behavioural learning strategies influence students' attitudes toward learning.
2. Describe a real-life situation at home where behavioural learning principles can be applied. Explain how stimulus, response, and reinforcement or punishment are used to influence behaviour. What impact does this have on the individual's skills or attitude?

Reference

- Woolfolk, A. (2016). *Educational Psychology (13th ed.)*. Pearson Education.

6.2. Classical conditioning

Learning activity 6.2



At school, students are used to having lunch every day at exactly 12:00 p.m. Over time, they begin to feel hungry as soon as the clock approaches 12:00, even before seeing or smelling any food. One day, you go to the dining room at 12:00 as usual, but you find that the food is not yet ready.

1. "What usually happens at 12:00 every day at school?"
2. "Can you identify what in this situation might be causing your hunger? The food itself, or something else?"

6.2.1. Description of classical conditioning

Ivan Pavlov developed the idea of Classical Conditioning through his experiment with dogs. Classical conditioning is a learning process in which a connection is formed between two stimuli so that one stimulus begins to produce a response that normally comes from another stimulus.

In Pavlov's experiment, the smell of food naturally made the dogs salivate, while the sound of a bell was at first a neutral stimulus because it did not cause salivation.

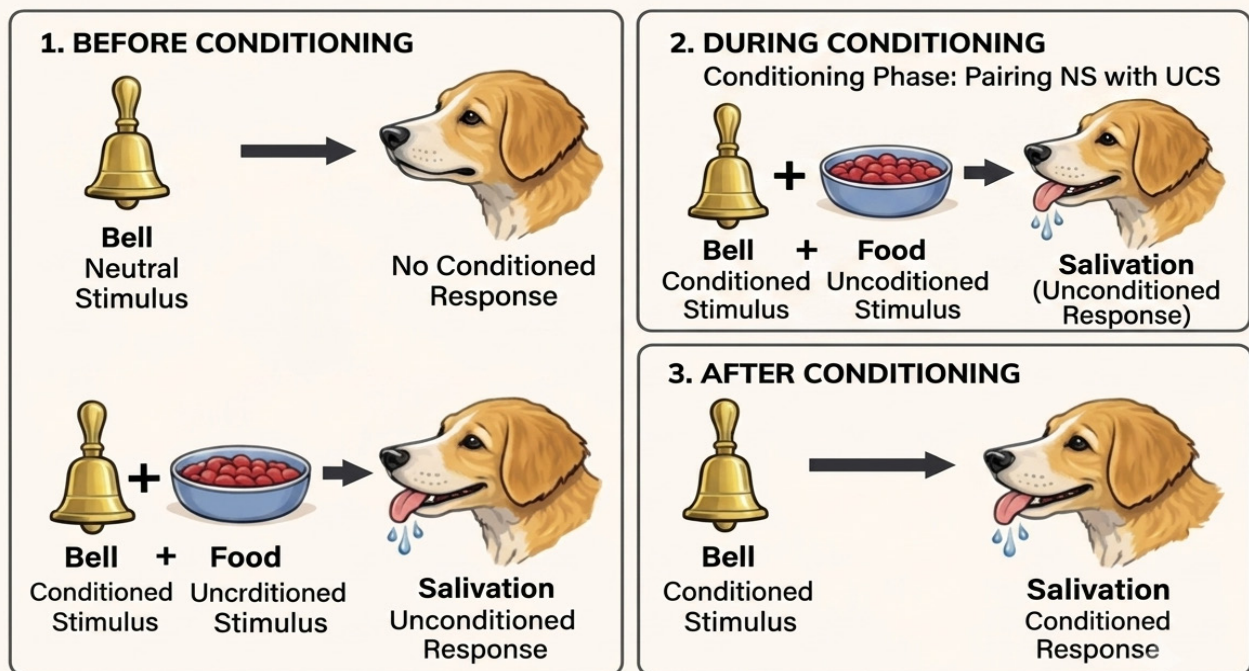
Pavlov repeatedly rang the bell before giving the dogs food, and after several repetitions, the dogs learned to associate the bell with food. Eventually, the sound of the bell alone caused the dogs to salivate even without food present.

This showed that a neutral stimulus could produce a learned response after being paired with a natural stimulus (Slavin, 2012).

6.2.2. The experiment of classical conditioning

The three steps of classical conditioning are as follows: **Before conditioning, during condition and after conditioning**. Researchers describe the stimuli and responses in specific scientific terminology at each stage. The diagram below illustrates the three steps of classical conditioning.

CLASSICAL CONDITIONING



Unconditioned stimulus (UCS) naturally triggers a reflex or automatic response without any learning. Example: Dogs salivate when they smell food.

Neutral stimulus (NS) does not cause any reaction at first. Example: The sound of a bell before it is associated with food.

Conditioning occurs when a neutral stimulus links with an unconditioned stimulus and eventually triggers the response on its own.

Conditioned and unconditioned response

A conditioned stimulus (CS) activates a conditioned response (CR) after conditioning. Before conditioning, a CS is a neutral stimulus (NS) that cannot elicit the target response. After repeated pairing with an unconditioned stimulus (US), the neutral stimulus (NS) becomes a conditioned stimulus (CS) and triggers a conditioned response (CR).

6.2.3. Basic features of the classical conditioning model of learning

Acquisition phase: During this period, an organism learns to associate the conditioned stimulus with the unconditioned stimulus.

Generalisation: This is the principle by which a stimulus similar to, but not identical to, the CS elicits a CR. The more similar a new stimulus is to the original CS, the more likely it is to elicit the CR.

Discrimination: The organism learns to differentiate the CS from other similar stimuli.

Extinction: Extinction, or cessation of the conditioned response (CR), occurs when researchers present the conditioned stimulus (CS) repeatedly without the unconditioned stimulus (UCS). Once extinguished, the conditioned response (CR) reactivates in much less time than it took to acquire in the first place.

Spontaneous Recovery: A CR will sometimes reappear spontaneously after extinction.

Higher Order Conditioning: The conditioned stimulus (CS) uses its newly acquired strength to condition the same response to other stimuli.

Application activity 6.2



1. Using Pavlov's experiment, explain why the dogs eventually salivated to the bell alone.
2. Evaluate whether classical conditioning is an effective method for long-term behaviour change.
3. How can classical conditioning promote values like responsibility, discipline, and patience?
4. Analyse the three stages of classical conditioning in Pavlov's experiment and explain the role of each stimulus.

Reference

Slavin, R. E. (2012). *Educational Psychology: Theory and practice (10th ed.)*. Pearson.

6.3. Operant Conditioning

Learning activity 6.3



Suppose you are responsible for cleaning your room and doing other household chores every day. One day, you neglect your duties, leaving your room messy and dishes unwashed. Your parents notice that the chores are not done properly. Consequently, they take away your privilege to use your phone or watch TV for the evening.

At first, you feel frustrated and upset about losing your free time. However, the next day, you make sure to clean your room thoroughly, wash the dishes, and complete all tasks on time to avoid losing privileges again.

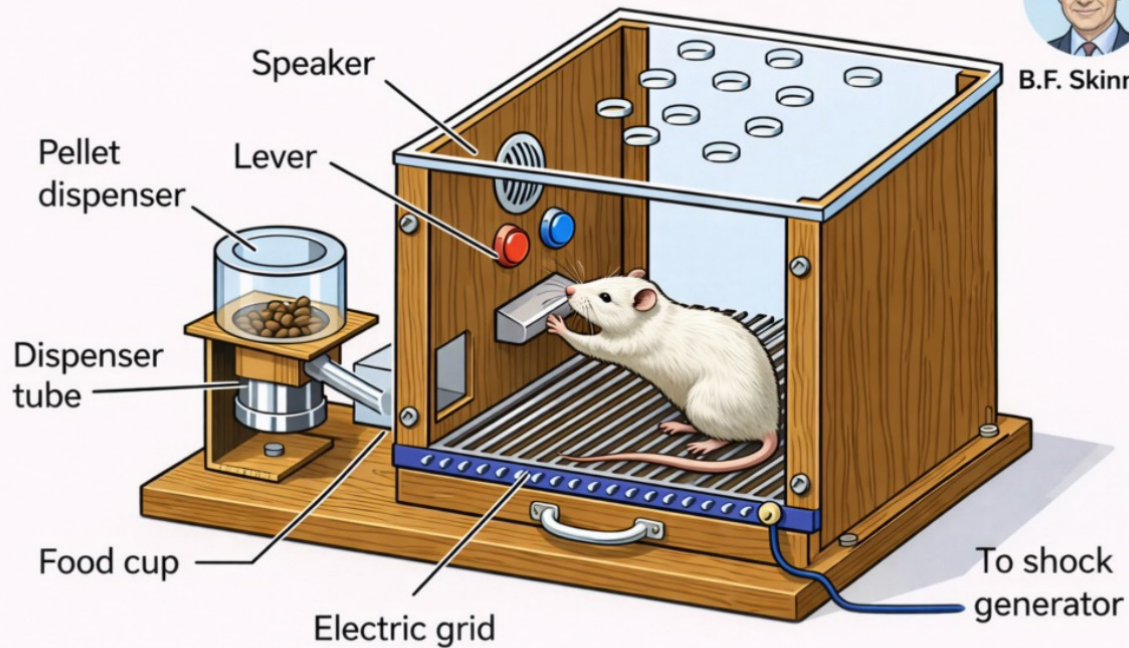
Questions:

1. How did you feel when your parents took away your phone or TV privileges?
2. How might this experience influence your attitude toward doing chores in the future?

6.3.1. Description of operant conditioning

A behaviourist, B.F. Skinner coined the term operant conditioning. Skinner conducted experiments with rats using a device called the Skinner box. The box was a cage set up so the rats could automatically get a food reward if they stepped on a lever. The lever caused food to be released. Reinforced behaviours strengthen, while punished behaviours weaken.

Skinner's Experiment with a Rat



6.3.2. Positive reinforcement

Positive reinforcement is part of Operant Conditioning. It strengthens desired behaviours by providing a reward or praise after the behaviour occurs, making it more likely to happen again in the future.

Some tips to Use Positive Reinforcement

- **Be aware of reinforcement timing and use the right reinforcement schedule:** Positive reinforcement works best when given immediately after a behaviour and delivered enthusiastically. The type and timing of reinforcement, as well as the schedule of presentation, influence how strongly and how often the behaviour is repeated
- **Deliver reinforcement quickly.** A shorter time between a behaviour and positive reinforcement makes a stronger connection.
- **Waiting risks reinforcing the wrong behaviours.** The longer the time, the more likely an intervening behaviour accidentally gains reinforcement.
- **Avoid Reinforcing the Wrong Behaviours.** Positive reinforcement can unintentionally encourage bad behaviour if given for misbehaviour. It is more effective when used to reward good behaviour instead. Example: A child at a local market in Kigali cries and shouts to get juice. If the parent gives the juice immediately to stop the crying, the child learns that misbehaviour brings rewards. Instead, if the parent gives the juice only after the child politely asks, the child learns to behave well in public and respect social norms.

6.3.3. Positive punishment

Positive punishment in Psychology is what we refer to as “punishment” in everyday life. We often use positive reinforcement when we want to suppress unwanted behaviour.

The Positive Effects of Punishment

Although “punishment” sounds inherently negative, it is not necessarily a negative thing. In operant conditioning, punishment is simply the discouragement of a behaviour.

Punishment does not necessarily stop when we become adults. Punishment can be effective in stopping undesirable employee behaviours, such as tardiness and absenteeism. These are some examples of positive punishment at home, school, and at work:

Scolding: Many children avoid reprimands or lectures, as employees dislike the boss verbally scolding them,

Hand slapping or grabbing. You might lightly slap the hand of a child reaching for a pot of boiling water on the stove, or who is pulling their sibling’s hair. You might forcefully grab or pull a child who is about to run into traffic.

Writing: This method is often used in school. For example, the child can be obligated to write the same sentence repeatedly or write an essay about their behaviour.

Rules. Few people crave more rules. For the child who frequently misbehaves, adding additional house rules might be an incentive to change a behaviour. Receiving an official warning for calling off work too often.

6.3.4. Negative reinforcement

Negative reinforcement strengthens a desired behaviour by removing or avoiding something unpleasant. When a behaviour occurs, the person removes an aversive stimulus to reinforce it. The behaviour is more likely to occur again in the future. A child cleans their room to stop their parent from constantly reminding them. The removal of the nagging (unpleasant stimulus) encourages the child to keep cleaning their room in the future.

6.3.5. Types of Negative Reinforcement

Escape Learning: Occurs when an individual performs a behaviour to stop or avoid something unpleasant. For example, a rat may press a lever in a Skinner box to stop an electric shock, and this learned behaviour later reinforces other desired actions.

Avoidance Learning: Avoidance learning occurs when an individual performs a behaviour (such as jumping over a hurdle) to avoid or escape an aversive stimulus (such as an electric shock). Once the rat has learned this behaviour, the loud noise serves as an aversive stimulus that can be used to reinforce other desired behaviours (such as going into dark compartments, even when there is no aversive stimulus present) (Dozier, Foley, Goddard, & Jess, 2019).

Application activity 6.3



1. Define positive reinforcement and positive punishment.
2. Describe why timing and schedule are important in positive reinforcement.
3. Discuss the consequences of reinforcing the wrong behaviour at home or school.
4. How can positive reinforcement promote self-esteem and motivation in learners?
5. Describe why a behaviour learned through avoidance learning might occur even without the aversive stimulus present.

Reference

Dozier, C. L., Foley, E. A., Goddard, K. S., & Jess, R. L. (2019). Reinforcement. In *Encyclopedia of Child and Adolescent Development* (pp. 1–10). Wiley

6.4. Strategies for using behavioural learning in different lifestyles

Learning activity 6.4



How do we apply behaviourism principles, such as reinforcement, punishment, and conditioning, to real-life situations at home, at school, or in daily routines? Give specific examples of behaviours that could be encouraged or reduced and explain the impact on a person's habits, skills, or attitudes."

Habit formation is one of the most powerful applications of behavioural learning. It explains how repeated behaviours become automatic responses through reinforcement and consistency.

Performance-based reinforcement uses rewards or consequences that directly match how well someone performs a task. We base behaviourism on the idea that behaviour followed by desirable outcomes is more likely to repeat, especially when those outcomes depend on performance quality or achievement (Black & Bright, 2019).

Environmental conditioning is a behavioural learning strategy that focuses on how **your surroundings influence your behaviour**. People respond automatically to environmental cues, often without conscious thought, and we base this principle on that idea. By designing your environment intentionally, you can make positive behaviours easier and negative ones harder.

Gradual shaping: A complex behaviour is developed gradually by reinforcing small improvements along the way. Instead of expecting immediate perfection, you reward progress in stages until the desired behaviour is fully formed.

Avoiding punishment-based systems: encouraging positive behaviour through reinforcement rather than discouraging negative behaviour through punishment. While punishment may stop behaviour temporarily, it often fails to produce lasting, healthy change.

Modelling behaviour. Instead of relying only on direct rewards or punishments, people adopt behaviours by watching what others do and what happens to them.

Application activity 6.4



1. Analyse the relationship between habit formation and environmental conditioning. How does your surrounding environment influence the development of automatic behaviours, and why is this relationship important in daily life?
2. Evaluate the effectiveness of performance-based reinforcement versus punishment-based systems. Which strategy is more likely to produce long-term behaviour change, and why? Support your answer with real-life examples.

Reference

Black, J. S., & Bright, D. S. (2019). *Reinforcement and behavioural change*. In *Organizational Behaviour* (Sec. 4.2). OpenStax. <https://openstax.org/books/organizational-behavior/pages/4-2-reinforcement-and-behavioral-change>.

6.5. End unit assessment



Knowledge and Understanding

1. Identify the main types of behavioural learning
2. Describe the key features of classical conditioning.
3. Explain how behaviour is acquired and maintained through conditioning in everyday life

Skills

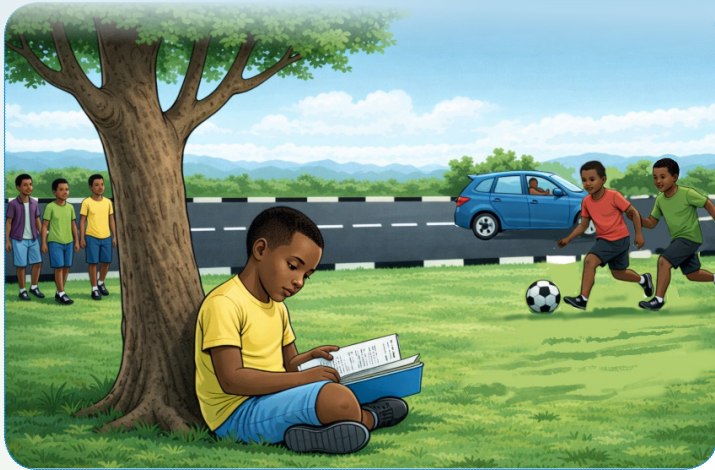
4. Design a simple behaviour modification plan to improve a specific behaviour (e.g., punctuality, studying habits).
5. Assess the effectiveness of reinforcement versus punishment in changing behaviour. Justify.

Attitudes and Values

6. Explain the role of environment and experience in shaping behaviour.
7. Describe a personal experience where reinforcement or punishment affected your behaviour.
8. Demonstrate how you can apply behaviourist principles to improve your own self-discipline.

UNIT 7

MEMORY AND INTELLIGENCE



Key Unit Competence:

Analyse the nature and stages of memory processing and the way intelligence influences human behaviour.

Learning objectives

By the end of this unit, you should be able to:

Knowledge and understanding

1

- Define memory and intelligence.
- Identify different stages of processing memory.
- Explain effective strategies that improve memory retention and recall.
- Explain the interference and trace decay theories of forgetting.
- Distinguish types of intelligence.
- Identify intellectual disabilities.
- Describe the impact of intellectual disability on students' achievement.
- Explain how memory and intelligence aid in learning vocabulary, grammar, and communication skills.

Skills

2

- Illustrate the stages of memory.
- Assess different types of intelligence (such as linguistic, logical, spatial, interpersonal, etc.).
- Evaluate the effectiveness of personal memory-enhancement techniques.
- Organise information into meaningful patterns or structures for better long-term retention.
- Assess personal strengths and weaknesses in various cognitive abilities.
- Link memory and intelligence in learning tasks (e.g., using memory strategies to enhance problem solving).

Attitudes and values

- Show interest in exploring how memory and intelligence affect learning.
- Live and deal with all people, respecting their individual differences in terms of intelligence capabilities.
- Refer to research on intelligence to understand how people do the way they do.
- Show sensitivity toward learners with intellectual disabilities.

Introduction

Memory and intelligence are two fundamental aspects of human cognition that play a crucial role in learning, problem-solving, and everyday functioning. Together, they form the foundation of how individuals acquire knowledge and apply it effectively. This unit explores the concept of memory and intelligence, beginning with an understanding of what they are and how they operate. It examines the levels of memory processing and practical strategies for enhancing memory. It also discusses key theories of forgetting, particularly interference and trace decay theories. Furthermore, it explores different types of intelligence and shows how they influence learning abilities. It also examines intellectual disability and explains its impact on cognitive functioning. Finally, the unit emphasises the important roles that memory and intelligence play in language learning.

Introductory activity



Two students, Mukunzi and Keza, are learning English in the same class. Mukunzi is very quick at understanding grammar rules. He can easily explain how sentences are structured and performs well in written exercises. However, he often forgets new vocabulary and struggles to recall words during conversations. He usually studies by reading textbooks and memorising rules the night before tests. Keza, on the other hand, takes longer to understand grammar rules, but she remembers vocabulary very well. She practices speaking regularly with classmates, uses flashcards, and connects new words to real-life situations. She rarely forgets words once she has learned them and communicates more confidently in class. After several weeks, the teacher notices that Mukunzi performs better in grammar tests but struggles in speaking activities. Keza performs better in speaking and vocabulary, but makes some grammatical errors. The teacher decides to help both students improve by introducing different learning strategies.

Questions

1. What differences do you notice between Mukunzi and Keza in terms of memory and learning?
2. What is the role do practice and repetition play in Keza's success?
3. Which learner do you relate to more, and why?

7.1. Understanding memory and intelligence

7.1.1. Memory

Learning activity 7.1

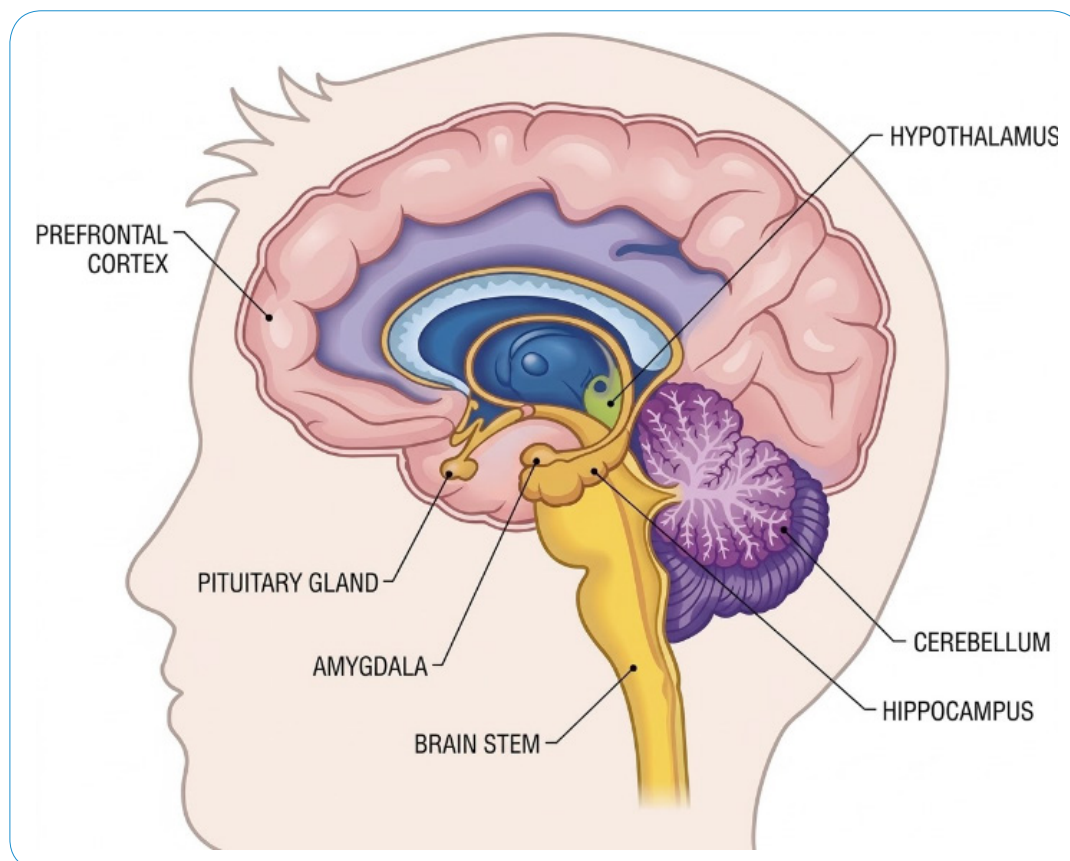


In a language class, the teacher introduces 10 new English words. All students have 15 minutes to study them. After the lesson: Karangwa quickly memorises all the words but forgets most of them the next day. Umwiza remembers fewer words at first, but after practising them in sentences and conversations, she can still recall them a week later. Karabo understands the meanings of the words very well but struggles to remember their exact spelling. Kamaliza not only remembers the words but also uses them correctly in speaking and writing.

1. Why do you think the students had different results even though they learned the same words?
2. Which student showed better long-term memory? Why?
3. How do practice and use of language affect memory?

Memory is the ability of an organism to encode, store, retain, and retrieve information and experiences when needed. It enables individuals to preserve what they have learned and recall it for use in different situations, such as problem-solving or answering questions (Atkinson & Shiffrin, 1968).

Memory structures



The brain's memory system is a complex network involving several key regions that work together to encode, store, and retrieve information.

Hippocampus: Located in the temporal lobe, it is essential for forming new long-term memories and spatial navigation.

Amygdala: This attaches emotional significance to memories, particularly those related to fear or reward.

Prefrontal Cortex: This area is responsible for “working memory”, the ability to hold and manipulate information in the short term and helps organise memories chronologically.

Cerebellum: While often associated with movement, it plays a vital role in procedural memory, such as learning how to ride a bike or play an instrument.

7.1.2. Intelligence

Intelligence is the mental ability to learn from experience, understand complex ideas, think logically, solve problems, and adapt effectively to new situations. It involves a combination of cognitive skills such as reasoning, memory, critical thinking, and the ability to apply knowledge in different contexts.

Intelligence is not viewed as a single ability but as a set of related mental capacities that work together to help individuals function effectively in their environment. These abilities enable people to process information, make decisions, and respond appropriately to challenges in everyday life (Sternberg, 2024).

Application activity 7.1



1. Explain why intelligence is considered a set of related mental capacities rather than a single ability.
2. Define memory and list the key memory structures in the brain and their functions

Reference

- Atkinson, R. C., & Shiffrin, R. M. (1968). *Human memory: A proposed system and its control processes*. In K. W. Spence & J. T. Spence (Eds.), *The Psychology of learning and motivation* (Vol. 2, pp. 89–195). Academic Press.
- Sternberg, R. J. (2024). *Human intelligence*. In *Encyclopaedia Britannica*. Retrieved March 18, 2026, from <https://www.britannica.com/science/human-intelligence-Psychology>

7.2. Levels of processing memory

Learning activity 7.2



Imagine you receive a text message invitation to a party. You look at it quickly, memorise the date and time for a few seconds. Later, you try to recall it, but you can only remember a few details. Another day, a friend sends a similar invitation, but this time you imagine the party, think about who you will meet, and picture what you might wear. A week later, you can recall most of the details easily.

1. Why were you able to remember the second invitation better than the first?
2. How does thinking deeply about the details of the party help transfer information into a more permanent memory?

Memory is not a single system but consists of multiple distinct systems. The widely accepted model identifies three major types: **Sensory Memory, Short-Term Memory (STM), and Long-Term Memory (LTM)**. Information moves through these systems gradually, but only when we pay attention to it without focused awareness does it progress to the next stage.

7.2.1. Sensory memory

Sensory memory refers to the brief storage of sensory information. Sensory memory is a memory buffer that lasts only very briefly and then, unless it is attended to and passed on for more processing. The purpose of sensory memory is to give the brain some time to process the incoming sensations.

7.2.2 Short-term memory

Short-term memory is the system in the brain responsible for holding and processing a limited amount of information for a brief period, typically from a few seconds up to about 20–30 seconds. It acts as a temporary workspace where information is kept active for immediate use, such as remembering a phone number just long enough to dial it.

Most of the information that gets into sensory memory is forgotten, but information that we turn our attention to, to remember it, may pass into short-term memory (Baddeley, Vallar, & Shallice, 1990).

7.2.3 Long-term memory

Long – Term Memory (LTM): It refers to the memory system for the retention of large amounts of information for long periods. The memory system permits us to remember events that happened many years ago, yesterday, last year, and so on.

When we pay attention to a piece of information and engage in active rehearsal, the material is stored in the long-term memory (LTM). Information in sensory memory enters short-term memory when it becomes the focus of our attention. If we do not pay attention to the incoming sensory information, the material fades and quickly disappears. We tend to pay attention to certain information and not to others. Paying

attention to certain aspects of our world is what we call **“selective attention”**. We often rehearse the information from STM. This rehearsal helps the transfer of that information from STM to LTM.

Implicit Memory

Implicit memory, also called non-declarative memory, is a type of long-term memory that operates without conscious awareness. Unlike explicit (declarative) memory, which involves remembering facts or events intentionally, implicit memory influences our behaviour, skills, and responses automatically, without the need to recall the information. Examples: Typing on a phone without looking at the keys, driving a familiar route automatically.

Explicit Memory

Explicit memory, also called declarative memory, is a type of long-term memory that involves conscious, intentional recollection of information, events, or experiences. It allows individuals to recall knowledge and experiences deliberately and communicate them verbally or in writing.

Application activity 7.2



1. Define sensory memory, short-term memory, and long-term memory
2. Describe how information moves from short-term memory to long-term memory.
3. Which memory system do you think is most critical for learning a new language, and why?
4. Using examples, differentiate between implicit memory and explicit memory. Provide at least one example of each to support your answer.

Reference

Baddeley, A. D., Vallar, G., & Shallice, T. (1990). *Short-term memory*. In G. Vallar & T. Shallice (Eds.), *Neuropsychological impairments of short-term memory* (pp. 54–73). Cambridge University Press.

7.3. Strategies for enhancing memory

Learning activity 7.3



A teacher gives three students: Ganza, Hirwa, and Uwera, the same list of 15 new vocabulary words in a foreign language. They each use different strategies to remember the words for a test the next day: Ganza reads the list repeatedly quietly but does not use any other method. Hirwa writes each word multiple times and says them aloud, connecting each word to an image or personal experience. Uwera creates flashcards and practices a little every day, reviewing the difficult words more often.

1. Which student do you think will remember the most words? Why?
2. How does repetition help in retaining information in memory?

Memory enables us to encode, store, and retrieve information, but forgetting can occur. To improve retention, strategies such as attention, rehearsal, and other memory-enhancing techniques are recommended (Baddeley, Eysenck, & Anderson, 2020).

Understand the material: To remember information effectively, you need to understand it and relate it to what you already know.

Organise your learning material: Grouping related concepts and showing their relationships using tools like mind maps or Venn diagrams helps you understand and remember their relevance.

Have the right study environment: Studying in a distraction-free environment is essential, as paying attention is crucial for effectively processing and learning new concepts.

Space out your work: Focus on small amounts of material at a time to improve memory and retention.

Use mnemonic methods: Using rhymes, jokes, or songs and connecting concepts to familiar ideas makes them easier to remember.

Repetition: Repeated practice, such as writing, saying, or drawing, helps store new skills and concepts in long-term memory.

Get enough sleep: Research suggests that getting enough sleep is important for retaining information more effectively. It is, therefore, a good idea to take a nap after learning a new concept for the first time. Make sure that you also get enough sleep at night, as this can affect your energy levels for the next day.

Chunking is a memory strategy where individual pieces of information are grouped into larger, meaningful units to make them easier to remember. Example: Remembering a phone number as 123-456-7890 instead of 1-2-3-4-5-6-7-8-9-0.

Overlearning: That is, continuing to practice and study even when we think that we have mastered the material.

Application activity 7.3



1. Explain why understanding the material helps with long-term memory.
2. Analyse how using a distraction-free environment affects rehearsal and understanding of material.
3. Which strategy: mnemonics, chunking, or repetition would you recommend for learning historical dates? Justify your choice.

Reference

Baddeley, A., Eysenck, M. W., & Anderson, M. C. (2020). *Memory* (3rd ed., pp. 1–20). Psychology Press.

7.4. Interference and trace decay theories of forgetting

Learning activity 7.4



Two students, Cyusa and Gwiza, are preparing for a test. Cyusa studies a list of vocabulary words in the morning. After studying, he does nothing related to school and spends the rest of the day relaxing. The next day, he struggles to remember many of the words. Gwiza studies a similar list of vocabulary words, but immediately after, he studies another subject with many new terms that are quite similar. During the test, he mixes up the meanings of the words and gets confused.

1. Why did Cyusa forget the vocabulary words?
2. Why did Gwiza confuse the words he learned earlier with the new ones?
3. Which students' forgetting is due to lack of use over time?
4. Which students' forgetting is caused by interference from other information?

7.4.1. The interference theory

The interference: Information stored under similar categories tends to conflict with each other. There are two types of interference:

Proactive interference: Old information interferes with learning or recalling new information.

Retroactive interference. New information interferes with recalling old information.

Chandler (1989) stated that students who study similar subjects at the same time often experience interference.

7.4.2. The Trace Decay Theory

Trace Decay Theory explains forgetting because of the gradual fading of memory over time. According to this theory, when information is learned, it creates a memory trace (a physical or chemical change) in the brain. If this trace is not used, rehearsed, or revisited, it weakens and eventually disappears.

When we learn something new, the brain undergoes neurochemical changes called memory traces. Memory retrieval requires us to revisit those traces that the brain formed when encoding the memory. The trace decay theory implies that the length of time between the memory and recalling determines whether we will retain or forget a piece of information. The shorter the time interval, the more we will remember, and vice versa.

For example, regular use of a computer password keeps your memory trace strong. However, occasional use of the same weakens the memory trace, making it difficult to remember the password.

7.4.3. Retrieval Failure Theory

Some psychologists maintain that forgetting can be explained by the inability to retrieve from memory, rather than by simple memory loss, distortion, suppression, or interference. In other words, individuals do not appear to remember simply because of what is termed retrieval cue failure. The “retrieval cue failure” refers to the inability to recall an item of information from memory. Retrieval failure happens when information remains in long-term memory but cannot be accessed. This means the memory is available but not accessible. We often fail to retrieve memories because the retrieval cues are missing. Each time we store a new memory, we also store details about the situation. These details act as cues, and when we face the same situation again, they can trigger recall of the memory.

Application activity 7.4



1. Identify and explain the two types of interference.
2. Evaluate how rehearsal helps reduce forgetting according to both theories
3. Describe a situation where forgetting occurs due to trace decay
4. What is Retrieval Failure Theory, and how does it explain forgetting?

Reference

Chandler, P., & Sweller, J. (1989). *Cognitive load theory and the format of instruction. Cognition and Instruction*, 8(4), 293–332.

7.5. Types of intelligence

Learning activity 7.5

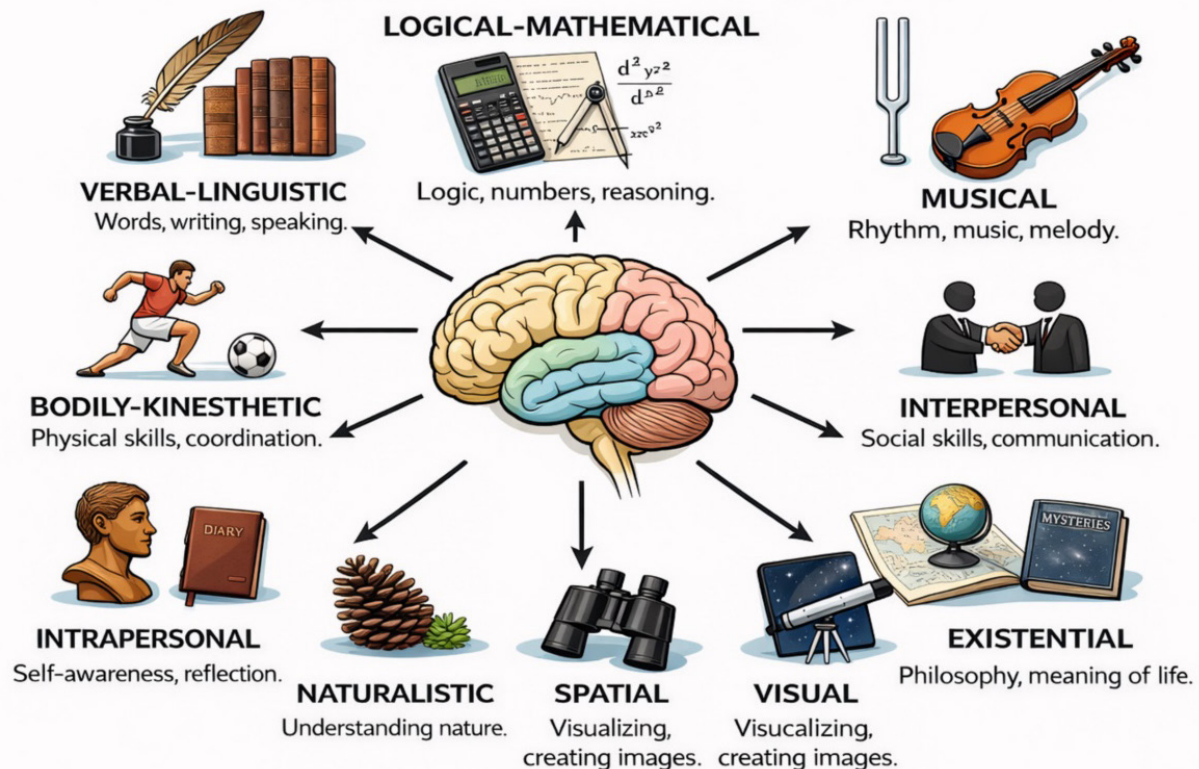


Our school is hosting a “Talent Day”, where students are encouraged to highlight their strengths in different activities. During the event, Murindwa excels at solving puzzles quickly and enjoys logic games. Cyuzuzo creates a beautiful painting and is able to express deep emotions through art. Nyirabigwi is a natural at helping her friends solve social problems and mediating conflicts. Shema can play multiple musical instruments and compose short melodies easily.

1. Based on the scenario, which type of intelligence does Murindwa demonstrate? Explain why.
2. How is Cyuzuzo’s strength different from Murindwa’s in terms of intelligence?
3. Why is it important to recognise different types of intelligence in people?

Intelligence goes beyond academics and includes various skills that help individuals adapt and succeed in life. According to Gardner (2011), people possess different types of intelligence, such as logical-mathematical, linguistic, musical, bodily-kinaesthetic, interpersonal, intrapersonal, and naturalistic, which help them learn and solve problems effectively.

THEORY OF MULTIPLE INTELLIGENCES



Howard Gardner suggests that intelligence is not a single general ability, but a combination of different types of intelligences. Gardner argued that people have multiple ways of being smart, such as in language, music, logic, or social understanding.

Multiple intelligence theory

Type of Intelligence	Features	Example
1. Linguistic	Sensitivity to spoken and written language; ability to use language effectively	Writing a story or giving a speech
2. Logical-Mathematical	Ability to think logically, reason, calculate, and solve problems	Solving a math puzzle or conducting a science experiment
3. Musical	Sensitivity to rhythm, pitch, melody, and tone	Playing an instrument or composing a song
4. Bodily-Kinaesthetic	Using one's body skilfully; coordination and physical control	Dancing, playing sports, or performing surgery
5. Spatial (Visual)	Ability to think in images and visualise accurately	Drawing, designing a room, or reading a map
6. Interpersonal	Understanding and interacting effectively with others	Leading a group, resolving conflicts, or teaching

Type of Intelligence	Features	Example
7. Intrapersonal	Self-awareness; understanding one's own feelings, motivations, and goals	Reflecting on personal strengths and weaknesses
8. Naturalistic	Sensitivity to nature and the environment; recognising patterns in nature	Identifying plants, observing animals, or gardening
9. Existential	Awareness of deeper questions about life, existence, and human purpose	Contemplating the meaning of life or philosophical thinking

This theory highlights that individuals have unique strengths and learning styles, and it encourages education systems to recognise and develop all types of intelligence rather than focusing on just academic abilities.

Application activity 7.5



1. Explain how bodily-Kinaesthetic intelligence differs from visual-spatial intelligence.
2. Give an example of someone in your life who demonstrates musical intelligence and explain why.
3. Evaluate which intelligence would be most useful for a pilot and justify your answer.

Reference

Gardner, H. (2011). *Frames of mind: The theory of multiple intelligences (10th anniversary ed.)*. Basic Books.

7.6. Intellectual disability

Learning activity 7.6



Dukundane is a 12-year-old student in your class. He struggles to learn some subjects at the same pace as his classmates and often needs extra guidance with reading, writing, and solving problems. Dukundane born prematurely and spent some time in intensive care after birth. Additionally, during early childhood, he had frequent illnesses that sometimes kept him from attending school regularly. Despite these challenges, Dukundane is very talented in drawing and enjoys helping others in-group activities. His teacher has noticed that he learns better when instructions are broken into smaller steps and when he has someone to guide him.

1. What challenges does Dukundane face in his learning compared to his peers?
2. How might Dukundane's experiences at birth and during early childhood affect his ability to learn?

American Association on Intellectual and Developmental Disabilities (AAIDD, 2010) defined Intellectual disability as "Significantly sub-average general intellectual functioning existing concurrently with deficit in adaptive behaviour and manifested during the developmental period that adversely affects a child's educational performance."

7.6.1. Causes of Intellectual Disability

Biological causes of intellectual disability

Types	Example	Characteristics and considerations
Chromosomal abnormality	Down syndrome	– Most common chromosomal abnormality – Distinctive physical characteristics – Generally mild to moderate intellectual disability
	Fragile X Syndrome	– One of the leading inherited causes of intellectual disability – Predominantly affects males – Distinctive physical features – Wide variation in learning characteristics
Metabolic Disorders	Phenylketonuria (PKU)	– Inborn error of metabolism, a recessive trait – Dietary intervention initiated shortly after birth prevents occurrence of intellectual disability
Maternal Infections	Rubella (German measles)	– One of the leading causes of multiple impairments in children – Exposure during first trimester of pregnancy – Usually results in severe consequences
Environmental Conditions	Foetal alcohol Syndrome	– One of the leading causes of intellectual disability – Mild to moderate intellectual disability with concomitant physical, deformities
Gestational Disorders	Low birth weight/prematurity	– Infant at risk for serious problems at birth – Potential for learning problems as well as sensory and/or major impairments – More common in mothers living in poverty, teenage pregnancy and women engaged in substance abuse

Types	Example	Characteristics and considerations
Neonatal complications	– Anoxia (oxygen deprivation) – Breech presentation – Prolonged Delivery	– Complicating factors surrounding birth may cause intellectual disability and other developmental delays
Infectious and intoxications	Meningitis	– Viral infection causing damage to the covering of the brain-the meninges – May result from typical childhood illness such as chicken pox or mumps – Intellectual disability is a distinct possibility

Other causes of Intellectual Disability

Non-biological causes are environmental or social factors that affect a child's intellectual development, usually after birth. These causes do not originate from genetics or brain malformations, but they can still significantly affect learning and adaptive functioning.

Psychosocial Deprivation

Lack of adequate stimulation, emotional support, or social interaction during early childhood, which can delay language development, social skills, and cognitive growth. Examples: Children raised in neglectful or abusive environments.

Environmental Toxins

Exposure to harmful chemicals outside the womb that affect brain development, which can result in learning difficulties and lower IQ levels. Examples: Lead poisoning from contaminated water, paint, or soil.

Malnutrition and Poor Diet

Insufficient nutrients during early childhood, critical for brain growth, can slow cognitive development and learning abilities. Examples: Vitamin and mineral deficiencies (e.g., iodine, vitamin B12).

Traumatic Brain Injury

Severe head injuries from accidents, falls, or abuse that damage the brain can impair memory, problem-solving, and adaptive behaviour. Examples: Car accidents.

Social and Cultural Factors

Lack of access to education, language, and cognitive stimulation in early childhood can slow intellectual growth and limit adaptive skills. Examples: Children in extreme poverty with limited schooling opportunities.

7.6.2. Characteristics of people with Intellectual Disability

Characteristics of people with intellectual disabilities that can affect their academic learning, as well as their ability to adapt to home, school, and community environments, are presented under the following points:

General Cognition: People with intellectual disabilities differ in physical, emotional, and personality traits. Their slower learning is often due to a delayed pace of intellectual development.

Learning and Memory: They learn more slowly than peers learn and have difficulty applying information to new situations.

Attention: May struggle to focus on relevant information and ignore distractions.

Adaptive Skills: Challenges in learning and applying skills due to distractibility, impulsivity, and difficulty reading social cues.

Self-Regulation: Underdeveloped ability to control, organise, and rehearse learning affects memory and task performance.

Speech and Language: Delayed speech and language comprehension, affecting communication and learning.

Motivation: Failures can lead to low motivation and learned helplessness.

Academic Achievement: Persistent difficulties in applying learned concepts, especially in problem-solving, despite mastering basic skills.

Application activity 7.6



1. List at least three biological causes of intellectual disability.
2. Explain how psychosocial deprivation can affect a child's cognitive development.
3. Analyse how low motivation can affect academic achievement in children with intellectual disabilities.
4. Critique the impact of social and cultural factors versus biological factors on a child's learning potential

7.7. Roles of memory and intelligence in language learning

Learning activity 7.7



Your class has just started learning a new foreign language. Three students are preparing for a vocabulary test: Nyiraneza repeats the words many times and practices them daily. Rukundo understands the meanings by connecting the words to real-life experiences and uses them in sentences. Keza learns quickly through songs, pictures, and group discussions, and enjoys interacting with others while practising the language. After a week, the teacher notices that each student has learned the words differently and performs well in different ways.

1. Which student relies most on memory to learn the new words? Why?
2. What type of abilities (intelligence) does Keza demonstrate while learning the language?

7.7.1. Role of Memory in Language Learning

Memory is crucial for acquiring, storing, and using language skills. Different types of memory contribute in distinct ways:

Short-Term Memory (STM)

Holds new vocabulary, sounds, or sentence structures temporarily. STM allows learners to process and practice language input before it is stored in long-term memory. Example: Remembering a new word long enough to use it in a sentence during conversation or practice.

Long-Term Memory (LTM)

Stores vocabulary, grammar rules, and idiomatic expressions over time. LTM is essential for fluency and automatic language use, as repeated exposure and rehearsal help consolidate learning. Example: Recalling the correct verb tense while writing an essay or speaking fluently.

Implicit Memory

Helps in mastering language rules without conscious awareness. Supports grammar acquisition, pronunciation patterns, and automatic sentence construction. Example: Using correct word order or forming plurals automatically in speech.

Explicit Memory

Stores factual knowledge about language, like vocabulary, rules, or meanings. Allows intentional learning and recall during study, reading, or writing tasks. Example: Remembering

7.7.2. Role of Intelligence in Language Learning

Intelligence influences how efficiently a learner can acquire, process, and apply a language. Different aspects include:

Linguistic Intelligence

Directly linked to vocabulary acquisition, comprehension, and communication skills. Example: Writing essays, storytelling, or learning foreign languages.

Logical-Mathematical Intelligence

Supports learning grammar and organising sentences logically. Example: Understanding grammar structures, sentence patterns, or syntax rules.

Interpersonal Intelligence

Enhances practical language use and communicative competence. Example: Engaging in conversations, group discussions, or language exchanges.

Intrapersonal Intelligence

Facilitates self-directed learning and motivation in language acquisition. Example: Monitoring one's own comprehension and adjusting study techniques.

Application activity 7.7



1. Explain how short-term memory and long-term memory work together to support language learning.
2. Evaluate which type of memory (STM, LTM, implicit, explicit) is most important for speaking fluently in a foreign language and justify your answer.

Reference

American Association on Intellectual and Developmental Disabilities. (2010). Intellectual disability: Definition, classification, and systems of supports (11th ed., p. 5). AAIDD

7.8. End unit assessment



Knowledge and understanding

1. Identify and explain the different stages of processing memory.

Skills.

2. Compare two types of intelligence and explain how each affects learning differently
3. Organise a set of vocabulary words into meaningful groups for better long-term retention.
4. Design a chart that links memory strategies to various problem-solving tasks in learning

Attitudes and values

5. Analyse how respecting individual cognitive differences can improve group-learning objectives.
6. Design a classroom rule or strategy that promotes respect for all types of intelligence among students.

UNIT 8

EMOTIONS



Key Unit Competence:

Demonstrate proper ways of coping with and managing emotions.

Learning objectives

By the end of this unit, you should be able to:

1 Knowledge and understanding

- Define emotions and explain their role in human behaviour.
- Identify and classify different types of emotions.
- Describe major theories of emotions.
- Explain the relationship between stress, emotions, and well-being.
- Describe strategies for maintaining emotional wellbeing.
- Explain major emotional coping mechanisms and stress management.
- Identify elements that lead to a sense of wellbeing.

2 Skills

- Analyse effects of stress on the human body.
- Compare and contrast theories of emotions.
- Develop tips which may help individuals cope with and manage stress.
- Use strategies to enhance personal well-being and emotional balance.

Attitudes and values

3

- Value the importance of emotional management to enhance well-being.
- Appreciate the process of managing individuals' emotions.
- Demonstrate empathy and understanding toward others' emotions.
- Show responsibility for managing one's own emotional health.
- Develop a positive attitude toward applying stress management and wellbeing strategies.
- Value emotional wellbeing as an essential component of overall health.

Introduction

Feelings and inner experiences play an important role in shaping how people behave and interact with others in their daily lives. They influence relationships and reactions to different situations, making them an essential part of human life. This unit explores the concept of emotions by helping you recognise these experiences and understand why they matter in everyday life. It introduces the different types of emotions and examines key theories that explain how these feelings develop and influence behaviour. The unit also highlights the importance of managing stress effectively and provides practical strategies to cope with emotional challenges. Finally, it emphasises overall wellbeing, encouraging you to build healthy emotional habits that support a balanced and fulfilling life.

Introductory activity



In a family of four, each member is experiencing different feelings on the same day. The father has just returned home after losing an important business deal, and he feels disappointed and worried about the future. The mother, on the other hand, has received good news about a job opportunity, and she feels excited and hopeful. Their daughter is upset because she had a disagreement with her close friend at school, while their son is happy after being selected to join the school football team.

Questions:

1. What feelings is each family member experiencing?
2. Why do people in the same family experience different feelings at the same time?
3. How might each person's feelings affect their behaviour during dinner?

8.1. Understanding emotions

Learning activity 8.1



Mugisha, a 15-year-old student, has been behaving differently over the past week. One day, he is cheerful and actively participates in class. The next day, he becomes quiet and avoids talking to his friends. At home, his parents notice that he sometimes gets irritated easily, especially when asked about school. One evening, Mugisha receives a message that he has not been selected for a school competition that he was very excited about. He becomes disappointed and withdraws from family activities. However, later that night, his younger sister makes him laugh, and he begins to feel better.

Questions

1. What different emotions is Mugisha experiencing in the scenario?
2. Why do Mugisha's emotions change at different times?
3. How do his emotions affect his behaviour at school and at home?

8.1.1. Emotions

Emotions are complex inner experiences that reflect how individuals respond to different situations, events, or thoughts in their daily lives. They involve a combination of feelings, physical reactions in the body, and outward expressions such as facial expressions or actions. For example, a person may feel joy when something good happens or fear when faced with danger. These experiences help people make sense of what is happening around them and guide how they react to different circumstances (Schacter, Gilbert, & Wegner, 2011).

Emotions are closely connected to both the mind and the body. When a person experiences a strong feeling, the body may respond through changes such as a faster heartbeat, sweating, or a calm, relaxed state. At the same time, emotions influence thinking patterns, decision-making, and behaviour. For instance, feeling confident can encourage someone to take on challenges, while feeling anxious may cause them to avoid certain situations. This shows that emotions play an important role in shaping human actions and interactions.

8.1.2. Components of emotion

Physiological Component:

This refers to the physical changes that occur in the body when a person experiences a feeling. For example, the heart may beat faster when someone is afraid. Other reactions can include sweating, trembling, or changes in breathing.

Cognitive Component:

This involves how a person thinks about or interprets a situation. For example, if someone sees a dog, he or she may feel fear if he or she thinks the dog is dangerous.

Behavioural Component:

This refers to how emotions are expressed through actions, facial expressions, and body language. For instance, a person may smile when happy, cry when sad, or shout when angry.

Application activity 8.1



1. Explain the meaning of "Emotion"
2. List the three components of emotion.
3. Identify an emotion you felt in the last week and describe its physiological, cognitive, and behavioural components.
4. Explain how emotions influence both thinking and behaviour.

Reference

Schacter, D. L., Gilbert, D. T., & Wegner, D. M. (2011). *Psychology* (2nd ed.). Worth Publishers.

8.2. Types of emotions

Learning activity 8.2



During a family weekend outing, three siblings are experiencing different feelings. Bwiza, the eldest, feels excited because she gets to ride a roller coaster for the first time. Irakoze, the second child, feels nervous, as he is afraid of heights. Uwase, the youngest, feels angry because she lost her favourite toy earlier in the day. Meanwhile, their mother feels happy seeing her children enjoy the day together, and their father feels worried about the heavy traffic on the way home.

1. What different types of feelings are each family member experiencing?

8.2.1. Types of emotions

Psychologist Paul Ekman (1999) established the following six universal emotions:

Happiness: Many people strive for happiness, because it is a pleasant emotion, which goes with feelings of well-being and fulfilment. Smiling or speaking in an upbeat tone of voice are common ways to express happiness.

Sadness: We all experience sadness from time to time. Someone may express his or her sadness by crying, remaining silent, and/or withdrawing from others. Sadness can manifest as grief, hopelessness, or disappointment.

Fear: Fear can cause an increase in heart rate, racing thoughts, or the fight-or-flight response. It can be in response to real or perceived threats.

Disgust: A physical experience can provoke disgust by a physical experience, such as seeing or smelling decaying food, blood, or other bodily fluids or a lack of hygiene. Moral disgust can occur when someone witnesses another person doing something

immoral or distasteful to him or her.

Anger: Anger can be shown through facial expressions such as frowning, yelling, or violent behaviour.

Surprise: A pleasant or unpleasant surprise. When surprised, a person may open his or her mouth or gasp.

8.2.2. Emotional Development

Emotional Development is a process that most life forms go through as a child grows from dependence to fully functioning adulthood. It refers to the ability to recognise, express, and manage feelings at various stages of life, as well as to feel empathy for the feelings of others. Emotional development begins around the age of two (1) and reaches its maximum during the period of adolescence.

Application activity 8.2



1. Explain the types of emotions and their effect on human behaviour
2. Describe a time when you used nonverbal behaviours to express your emotions or to detect the emotions of others. What specific nonverbal techniques did you use to communicate?

Reference

Ekman, P. (1999). *Basic emotions*. In T. Dalgleish & M. Power (Eds.), *Handbook of cognition and emotion* (pp. 45–60). John Wiley & Sons.

8.3. Theories of emotions

Learning activity 8.3



Imagine that you are on a plane that you know is going to crash. What emotions would you experience, and how would you respond to them? Would the rush of fear cause you to panic, or could you control your emotions?

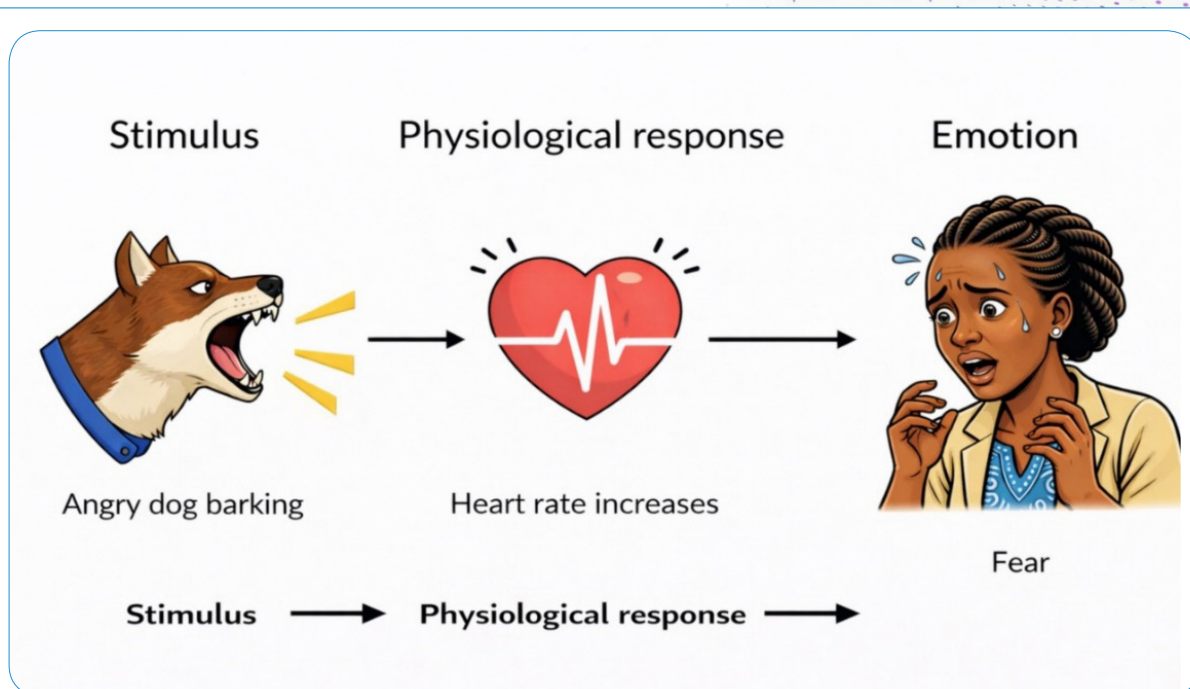
8.3.1. Physiological theories of emotions

Evolutionary Theory of Emotion:

Proposed by Charles Darwin, this theory says that emotions evolved because they help humans survive and reproduce. For example, fear makes people run from danger, while love and affection encourage bonding and reproduction (Ekman, 1999).

James Lange Theory:

This theory suggests that emotions happen because of physical reactions in the body. For example, you feel afraid because your body reacts, your heart races, and you start to sweat. In other words, your body reacts first, and your brain interprets these reactions as emotions.



Cannon-Bard Theory of Emotion

Cannon and Bard argued that emotions and physical reactions happen at the same time, not one after the other. For example, when you see a snake, you feel fear and your heart races simultaneously. The thalamus in the brain sends signals to both the body and the brain so that emotions and physical responses occur together.

8.3.2. Cognitive theories of emotions

The cognitive theory of emotion suggests that emotions are closely linked to thinking. How we interpret a situation based on experiences, culture, or current context affects how we feel and react emotionally. Cognitive theories fall into different categories that explore how thinking influences feelings and how we can understand emotions through mental processes.

Cognitive Arousal Theory of Emotion (Schachter-Singer).

This theory says that emotions have two parts: physical arousal (like a racing heart) and cognitive labelling (thinking about why you feel that way). You only experience an emotion when both happen together; for example, you feel afraid because your body is aroused and you interpret the situation as dangerous. The theory also explains the **Spillover effect**, where other people's emotions can influence how we feel. In short, arousal starts the emotion, and thinking directs it.

Cognitive Appraisal Theory (Lazarus)

Emotions depend on how we evaluate a situation. Even if we react quickly or automatically, our brain appraises whether something is harmful or safe, which shapes our emotional response

Zajonc and LeDoux's Theory:

Some emotional responses, like fear, happen automatically without conscious thinking, especially for survival. Later thinking may occur, but the initial reaction is immediate.

Application activity 8.3



1. Who proposed the Evolutionary Theory of Emotion, and what does it suggest?
2. Judge which theory (physiological or cognitive) better explains how emotions influence decision-making in daily life.
3. Analyse how thinking (cognition) and body reactions interact differently in the James-Lange theory versus the Cannon-Bard theory.

Reference

Ekman, P. (1999). *Basic emotions*. In T. Dalgleish & M. Power (Eds.), *Handbook of cognition and emotion* (pp. 45–60). John Wiley & Sons.

8.4. Stress management

Learning activity 8.4



While waiting to pay for foodstuffs at a certain shop, Mugisha had to wait about 20 minutes in a long line at the checkout because only one cashier was on duty. When Mugisha was finally ready to pay, his debit card was declined because he did not have enough money left in his checking account. Because Mugisha had left his credit cards at home, he had to place the foodstuffs back into the cart and head home to retrieve a credit card. While driving back to his home, traffic was backed up two miles due to an accident.

Question:

1. How might Mugisha manage his stress in this situation to stay calm and handle the delays and setbacks effectively?
2. What strategies could Mugisha use to prevent feeling overwhelmed when unexpected problems, like a declined card or traffic, occur?
3. How can recognising the sources of stress in this scenario help Mugisha respond more healthily?

8.4.1. Stress

Stress is the body and mind's response to demands or challenges, whether real or perceived. It happens when a situation feels overwhelming, threatening, or requires more effort than usual to handle.

External factors can cause stress, such as work pressure, school demands, family problems, financial issues, or traffic. It can also come from internal factors like worry, fear, negative thinking, or high personal expectations.



8.4.2. Stress management

Stress can affect the body, mind, and behaviour. Physically, it may cause headaches, fast heartbeat, or fatigue. Mentally, it can lead to anxiety, irritability, or difficulty concentrating. Behaviourally, stress may cause poor sleep, overeating, or withdrawal from others. When you manage stress, it has less impact on your health. The following are tips for managing stress:

Identify Sources of Stress

To manage stress, first recognise its sources, including major life events and daily habits or thoughts. Understanding your role in creating or maintaining stress helps you take control and reduce it.

Practice the 4 A's of stress management

To manage predictable stress, use the four A's: **Avoid** unnecessary stressors, **Alter** situations you can change, **Adapt** to stress you cannot control, and **Accept** unavoidable things.

Get moving

Physical activity helps reduce stress by releasing feel-good endorphins and distracting the mind from worries. Even small daily activities like walking, dancing, cycling, or playing active games can improve wellbeing and gradually build fitness.

Connect to others

Spending time with supportive friends or family reduces stress by calming the body and mind. Talking to good listeners strengthens bonds, improves resilience, and helps manage stress, even if they cannot solve the problem.

Make time for fun and relaxation

Taking time for yourself through leisure, enjoyable activities, humour, and relaxation practices helps reduce stress, recharge your energy, and keep your mind and body calm.

Manage your time better

Poor time management increases stress, but it can be reduced by avoiding over-commitment, prioritising tasks, breaking projects into small steps, and delegating responsibilities to others.

Learn to relieve stress in the moment

You can quickly reduce stress by using your senses or gentle movements, like deep breathing, listening to music or smelling a favourite scent.

Application activity 8.4



1. List three external and two internal causes of stress.
2. Explain how stress can affect the body, mind, and behaviour.
3. Imagine you have an upcoming exam and a family obligation on the same day. How could you use the four A's to manage your stress?
4. Judge which stress management strategy might be most effective for someone who feels constantly rushed and why.

Reference

American Psychological Association. (n.d.). Stress. In *APA Dictionary of Psychology*. Retrieved from <https://dictionary.apa.org/stress>.

8.5. Wellbeing

Learning activity 8.5



Kaliza is a high school student who has been feeling tired, stressed, and unmotivated lately. She notices she often skips meals, spends hours on her phone before bed, and rarely exercises. Her friends invite her to join a weekend hiking trip, but she worries she will not have the energy. After talking with her school counsellor, Kaliza decides to make small changes: she starts going to bed earlier, eats more meals that are balanced, spends some time exercising, and practices mindfulness for a few minutes each day. Over a few weeks, she notices she feels happier, more focused in class, and better able to handle stress.

1. What aspects of Kaliza's life were affecting her overall wellbeing before she made changes?
2. How did small changes in sleep, diet, exercise, and mindfulness improve her wellbeing?

Wellbeing is the state of being healthy, happy, and comfortable in life. It includes physical health (like exercise, nutrition, and sleep), mental and emotional health (like managing stress, positive thinking, and self-awareness), and social health (like supportive relationships and a sense of belonging) (Dodge et al., 2012).

8.5.1. The Elements of Wellness

Physical/Nutritional: Focuses on physical activity, diet, sleep and nutrition.

Emotional: Focuses on navigating through feelings and being able to share those feelings with others.

Social: Focuses on developing a sense of connection, belonging, and a well-developed support system.

Spiritual: Focuses on expanding our sense of purpose and meaning in life.

Intellectual: Focuses on creating abilities and finding ways to expand knowledge and skills.

Financial: Focuses on having satisfaction with current and future financial situations.

Environmental: This refers to your surroundings. It explains how they affect your health, wellbeing, and safety.

Occupational: Focuses on personal satisfaction and enrichment derived from one's work.



8.5.2. Factors affecting well-being

Adverse Childhood Experiences: Stressful or abusive childhoods can harm health, behaviour, and future productivity.

Home Background: Supportive homes promote positive development; neglect, poverty, or abuse harms well-being.

Positive Relationships: Stable, caring relationships build confidence and social development.

Enjoyable Career: Jobs that are fulfilling and challenging boost satisfaction and wellbeing.

Social Deprivation: Lack of social interaction leads to isolation and lower well-being.

Educational Experiences: Good education builds confidence, knowledge, and wellbeing.

Economic Factors: Poverty and financial stress negatively affect health and wellbeing; financial security supports it.

Diet: A healthy diet supports physical health, weight, and wellbeing.

Exercise: Regular activity improves fitness, self-esteem, and social engagement.

Religion and Culture: Shape values, behaviour, and expectations, influencing wellbeing.

8.5.3. Interventions for promoting well-being

People who age well maintain healthy diets, engage in regular physical activity, and remain actively involved in family and community life. Studies show that preventive strategies support health and well-being by promoting balanced living, healthy lifestyle choices, and early health care. These practices help prevent disease, maintain independence, and improve quality of life as people grow older.

A healthy lifestyle includes eating a balanced diet rich in fresh fruits, vegetables, fibre, and other nutrient-rich foods while limiting unhealthy foods and excessive calorie intake. Maintaining a healthy daily routine through regular exercise, walking, and effective time management also contributes to physical fitness, well-being, and longevity.

Good health also depends on emotional, social, and spiritual well-being. Practising self-control, positive thinking, emotional regulation, strong social relationships, and spiritual awareness helps individuals cope with challenges and maintain a healthy balance between the mind and body.

Preventive health care focuses on avoiding illness before it occurs and detecting diseases at an early stage. Healthy behaviours, health education, immunisation, regular health screening, self-examination, and timely treatment reduce the severity of diseases and improve health outcomes. By adopting these healthy habits and behaviours, individuals can maintain independence and enjoy a longer, healthier, and more fulfilling life.

Application activity 8.5



1. List the elements of wellness.
2. How would you apply healthy lifestyle practices to improve your daily wellbeing?
3. Assess the importance of education in improving wellbeing.
4. Propose a community program to promote healthy living and prevent illness.

Reference

Dodge, R., Daly, A. P., Huyton, J., & Sanders, L. D. (2012). *The challenge of defining wellbeing. International Journal of Wellbeing*, 2(3), 222–235. <https://doi.org/10.5502/ijw.v2i3.4>

8.5. End unit assessment



Knowledge and Understanding

1. Explain the relationship between stress, emotions, and wellbeing
2. List and classify the main types of emotions with examples.

Skills

3. Analyse how stress affects the human body physically and emotionally
4. Develop practical tips that can help individuals cope with stress in daily life.
5. Evaluate the effectiveness of different emotional coping mechanisms.

Attitudes and Values

6. Justify the importance of developing a positive attitude toward stress management strategies
7. Propose ways to promote emotional well-being in your school
8. Assess your own responsibility in managing your emotional health

9. PROJECT ACTIVITY

❖ Project title:

Influence of school environment on learning

❖ Objectives:

By the end of this project, you will be able to:

- Explain how school environment and emotions influence learning.
- Describe how memory and intelligence relate to learning.
- Identify factors that positively or negatively influence learning.
- Examine how personality traits influence learning.
- Suggest practical ways of creating a school environment that supports effective learning.
- Recognise the importance of creating an inclusive and supportive learning environment.

❖ Project Activity

As a S5 student, investigate how the school environment influences learning. Identify factors within the school environment that may positively or negatively affect students' learning, behaviour, memory, intelligence and emotional experiences. Use observation, a simple questionnaire and/or a safe, simple experiment to collect relevant information. Using the psychological knowledge you have acquired throughout the year, analyse your findings and apply relevant concepts and theories of learning and conditioning, personality traits, personality disorders, Social Learning Theory, memory and intelligence, and emotions.

Based on your findings, suggest practical ways of creating a school environment that promotes effective learning and positive behaviour.

❖ Project outline

After conducting your research and analysing the information collected, write a report. Your report should include:

1. **Introduction:** Briefly introduce the topic and explain the purpose of the research.
2. **Methodology:** Explain how you collected the data, including observation, questionnaire and/or experiment, the participants and the research setting.
3. **Findings:** Present the main findings from the data collected.
4. **Psychological Analysis:** Interpret the findings using relevant psychological concepts, theories and knowledge studied throughout S5.
5. **Conclusion:** Summarise the main findings and what they show about the influence of the school environment on learning.
6. **Recommendations:** Suggest practical ways to address the challenges identified and promote effective learning.
7. **Reflection:** Explain what you learned from conducting the research and how the project helped you apply Psychology to a real-life situation.

❖ Guiding questions

Your research should consider the following questions:

1. Which factors in the school environment appear to have the greatest influence on students' learning?
2. How do these factors influence students' learning and behaviour?
3. Are the effects positive, negative or both? Give examples from your findings.
4. How do rewards, consequences, repetition or other forms of conditioning influence students' behaviour and learning?
5. How might students' personality traits influence their study habits, motivation, participation and responses to learning?
6. How do students learn behaviours, attitudes or study habits by observing and interacting with others?
7. How do emotions influence students' concentration, motivation, learning and memory?
8. What factors appear to help or interfere with students' memory and recall?
9. What do your findings suggest about the role of intelligence in learning, understanding, problem-solving or applying knowledge?
10. Which psychological theory or theories studied in S5 can help explain your findings? How do they apply?
11. How can knowledge of personality help explain differences in students' behaviour without labelling or diagnosing individuals?
12. What conclusion can you draw about the influence of the school environment on learning?
13. What practical measures can be taken by the school, teachers, families and students to create an environment that supports effective learning?

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